Best Friend Squad rides again WITH A VENGEANCE!

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Teen And Up Audiences

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by the_Frank

Summary

Since the events in the last story, Catra and Adora is slowly worming their way back to a healthy relationship. For Adora, it was alright once Catra said she could come and visit when she wanted, and when visitations rights became unlimited. For Catra, things are a bit more complicated. How do you show someone you're really committed? How do you prove to someone who already gives you all the benifit of the doubt you could ask for that you really REALLY want this?

You decide that you need to do some big gesture, perform a huge gesture that shows what kind of stuff your made off. Slay a dragon. Become friends with your enemy.

Yeah, something like that.

Illustrations by the wonderful LORVIKK!!
Https://Tumblr.com/lorvikk

Prologue

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Months later. Winter had come, Christmas was approaching and for once, snow covered Brightmoon and its surroundings. For the health nut, it was a time of joy and endless possibilities for spontaneous exercise. For the couch potato, it was the ultimate time for sitting inside under a warm blanket drinking something nice and eating all the festive candy in sight.

Everyone who knew Adora knew that she was from category one. And everyone who knew Catra knew she was from the other.

While Catra did crawl to the gym a few times a week, that was more so she could burn enough calories to afford the bi-weekly pizza than an urge to stay particularly healthy.

So she had wide hips. Big deal. And while training and exercise was a necessary evil if she wanted to eat all the junk food she wanted, it was *not* a social event. It was *not* a suitable activity for a couple to do together and to suggest the *gym* as the place for a date was just plain stupid. Now, going down to lake Thaymor with the opportunity for the ones who wished for it to ice skate (Adora and Finn, the original jock nerds), the opportunity for more comfortable position at the lakeside cafe drinking the best hot cocoa in Etheria for anyone else? Not the ultimate date, but good enough.

She had just told all of this to Glimmer as they both emptied their third cup of hot chocolate with whipped cream. Third time's the charm, and it was completely necessary to consume so much of that beverage, which she also told Glimmer.

"And now we must have a fourth one."

"Catra, four cocoa in 30 minutes? Isn’t that a bit much?"

"Are they coming this way?"

"No, but…"

"Then another cup it is. Need to take the chance while you're paying. Garcon!"

"Catra, I know what I said, but…" but Catra shook her finger in Glimmer's face.

"Ah ah ah, sparky! You know the sitch, it's very simple." She pointed at Glimmer. "You:CEO, who used your magic business mumbo-jumbo powers to get here early and to sneak yourself five days worth of pumpkin pie before Arrowhead gets here."

Glimmer shook her head, and in an attempt to turn the spotligt to something else, she said,"Can you *please* stop calling him Arrowhead? Besides, look who's talking! If anyone sneaks pie from Razz, it's *you* !" Catra made a mock-hurt face and pointed at herself.

"Are you accusing ME of such unprofessional behaviour? Me, the newly promoted -and given a little but still, raise- first floor manager at the Holiday Inn who knows that you *lied* to him that you are at a conference here…"

"It's not a lie! It was a conference!"

"That ended yesterday. You COULD have gone home, but here you are, sneaking some early Christmas time off at said hotel where I work, me who COULD tell him about his wife's-to-be deceitful manners UNLESS said wife-to-be provides me with endless beverages. And we don't want Arrowhead, I mean Bow-man to be angry, do we? GARCON!"

Glimmer pinched her nose and laughed dryly. "It's Garçon, Catra… I think you've had enough."

"It's chocolate milk, not wine! What do you think I would do if I get too much, go MOOOO?"

Glimmer could do nothing but laugh, and Catra smiled the most shit-eating grin she could muster. But if she had a follow-up planned, it was drowned, as a red face arrived at the table, with their hair/mane with a slight hint of sweat and tons of excitement in it.

"Mom! Did you see me? Did you?" Finn was sparkling with excitement. They loved to skate and with Adora back in their life on a more permanent basis they finally had the opportunity to skate or, well actually perform *any* type of sport or exercise on a regular basis. Catra had been watching her kid pretty rudimentary so she did what every parent that loves their kid to bits does. She lied.

"I sure did! You're awesome! High five! Say, do you want hot chocolate? Auntie Glimmer's paying!"

"Hey!" But before she could protest more, Finn gave Glimmer a hug.

"Thanks Aunt Glim! You're the best!"

"Aren't you going to offer ME hot chocolate?" Adora had joined the table and sat down next to Catra. Adora was wearing an extremely long Santa hat that doubles as a scarf, which she now unfolded and placed around Catras neck, and giving her a peck on the cheek as she did so. Catra smiled, then placed a finger on her chin and gave a thoughtful expression.

"Hmmm. Do I want to offer my Ex-wife hot chocolate? I don't want to give her any idea that I like her." To which Adora snorted.

"Catra, I have been at your house looking after Finn every Friday for three months. AND we have been on six dates!"

"SIX Dates, Adora? Let's see about that! Two times we've visited your mom. One time we had dinner with Glim-glam here, one was literally you driving me home from work and as for the last two, as I just told sparkles, the *gym* is not the place for a date. If you can't find time in your schedule for both me AND your fix, why

should I bother? And if it's a subtle hint that my ass is too big, you can suck it!"

Adora blushed, and exclaimed, "I don't think your ass is too big!" Two seconds later, Adora realized what she just said and blushed. Glimmer burst out laughing again and Catra gave her another hurt look. "I mean… I didn't mean..." Glimmer interrupted. "Oh, so she HAS a big ass, but not big enough for it to be a problem? Interesting."

"I wonder how large an ass should be for Adora to find it problematic…." Catra added.

Adora looked around the table for support, but for nil. Catra smirked, Glimmer snickered and Finn shrugged their shoulders.

"Yeah, the gym *is* a shitty place for a date, mom. "

"It's… What do you know about dates anyway?" Adora gave her kid a long look. They shrugged their shoulders again.

"I read fanfiction. Gym dates always suck." Finn paused, and grinned. "unless it's porn."

Sometimes it showed that Finn was equally Catras' kid as they were Adoras.



Now it was Catra’s turn to burst out laughing, as Glimmer did a spit-take and sprayed hot chocolate and traces of cream over the table. Adora stared at Finn, not even noticing the mess. "I BEG YOUR PARDON?"

"Just kidding, mom."

Adora swallowed, then she pointed her finger at Finn.

"Oh just you wait! I am checking your AO3-account when we get home! You're way too young to even understand what's funny with that joke!"

Finn pouted. "Not fair mom! You read 50 shades of grey!"

"FINN!" Adora blushed intensely.

"Adora! That's a side of you I didn't know about!" Catra butted in. "Why, one could think you are trying to kink yourself up for me."

“Nah.” Glimmer added. “Don’t forget you’re talking to a lawyer. She would have you sign a written contract of ten pages for your full consent before she even dared to mention the word ‘leather’ around you.”

Adora shot up. "Finn! Here's my credit card! Get us three hot chocolates and a coffee! You can have a cinnamon bun if you want but go! Now!"

“With blueberries in it?”

“Whatever! Just go!”

Finn smirked and left. Once she had calmed down a bit, again Adora noticed how alike they were, her kid and her ex. Both had big fluffy hair which looked like fur in the right light (today enhanced by both of them wearing cat-eared ear muffs), both sported the same smirk and both being huge teases. Adora looked at Glimmer for support. But she only shrugged.

"Nope. If you want to read crap to impress Catra, that's on you completely."

Adora moped in her chair. "When did you two become besties anyway? You're supposed to be *my* friend!"

"I am your friend. But I am also Catra’s friend."

"Sharing is Caring, Adora…" Catra leaned over to give Adora a peck on her cheek. Adora blushed a little but brightened up. At least a bit.

"Okay, yeah but…" Adora paused and was silent long enough for Catra to interfere.

"Adora, please PLEASE don't go into full metal lawyer in front of us. We're just messing with you!"

Adoras head shot up. "I wasn't…!"

"You totally were."

"Yep. I saw that 'Gentlemen on the jury'-wrinkle on your forehead."

"Guys… Okay okay. I am glad you are friends again and yes, I have been worried and yes I have been advocating -NO PUN INTENDED- for it. But dagnabbit, lately the both of you seem to be getting along a little too well!"

"Oh? I seem to recall a certain someone who barely two weeks ago brought us together on a dinner date? And if we go further back, I remember the days of 'This is Glimmer, Catra.' 'Today we shall hang out with Glimmer, Catra.', Isn't Glimmer cool, Catra?' Are we doing something wrong to enjoy each other's company?"

Adora blushed and hmpfd. "NO, Catra! It's just that… Well, it's… things have changed in just a few weeks. That's pretty fast."

"Adora, people can change a lot in just a week. Like me, I got a haircut last Friday for our date, and you have... . No, forget that. You still got that stupid hair puff. It's just the cap that makes you look better."

"...Catra…."

"She means how we both tease the shit out of her." Glimmer added. She proceeded to take a sip from her almost empty cup, but she didn't care. It made her look nonchalant and cool.

"Yes, *that* , Glimmer!"

"Hmmm… You know, that is a good question…" Catra leaned forward, resting her head on her arms and gave Glimmer a thoughtful look. "Now, when *did* we start to get along so well?"

Glimmer leaned over the table as well, making her and Catra similar in posture, causing Adora to 'hmpf'. "Hmm. I dunno… It must have been...That wednesday night! …but exactly what did we bond over?

"It might have been the robbery."

"Mmmm...Or that crazy car chase."

"It wasn't a Car chase! It was more of a… heist."

"Yeah, it wasn't very much chasing… In the end, it just stood there."

"Mhm. OH! It was probably the burnt down barn."

"...guys?"

"Yeah! Or the cookies!"

"No, not the cookies."

"They were delicious, you tried them!"

"Guys!"

"They're okay. And it's biscuits. "

"Cookies, biscuits… same thing!"

"Not to her, and you should know that!"

"GUYS! Robbery?? Cabs? BISCUITS? Guys, wtf?"

Glimmer and Catra looked at Adora, then at each other. It struck both of them that this story was not something you told quick and easy with a simple punchline. It was long, complicated, with highs and lows and to be honest, neither of them had fully comprehended what actually had occurred. A silent conversation followed.

Eh…

Yeah. Good job getting Adora curious.

What? Is that MY fault? It's not like YOU did anything to stop it.

Whatever. Now we have to tell her.

Fuck.

Yep.

They looked at each other one last time and nodded in acquiesce. Then they looked at adora. "Welll…"

"It's actually a rather funny story…"

Chapter 1: Why are good deeds never easy to do?

Two weeks earlier...

While Adora paid the sitter (Finn was probably old enough for an evening on their own, but only just probably) Catra went upstairs to see if they were sleeping. She wasn't really curious, of course they were. She just needed to look at them, to calm herself down. She gently opened the door marked "World domination planning in progress 24/7. KEEP. OUT.' and slipped in. In the faint green light from the Gecko-figurine, Finn was sleeping soundly. They had thrown most of the cover off, catra gently pulled it up so they wouldn't be cold. She also picked up the dirty laundry, making a mental note that they probably needed to buy a new binder. Then she sat down in the chair and looked at her sleeping kid.

Why is *she like that?*

She let that thought sink.

...Why am I *like that…* she put that thought aside. In her mind she walked through, not the dinner with Glimmer, that was too much. But the ride home… It had been almost as bad, but not quite.

"Soooo...Did you have a good time?"

"Mmmm."

"Good. Good.... I had a really nice time."

"Good for you."

"It was a very nice restaurant."

"Yes. Nice. Cosy. A perfect place for a date*."*

"Yes. We had a nice time."

"You *had a nice time."*

"Oh. So…"

"What, Adora? So, what?"

"So… Um…Well… You seemed a bit…"

"A bit what *, ADORA? Insulted? Miffed? Trampled on?"*

"Glimmer didn't mean…"

"Sure she didn't."

"Catra… that was not what Glimmer meant! Her intention was purely to make conversation and…"

"Her intention. Purely. Objection, MISS GREYSKULL. You're not in court."

"I wasn't… Anyway, you said something…"

"What did I say now?"

"Well… Catra… It was a very mean thing to say."

"It was just a joke! Her dress made her look like a Rhino! Grey isn't her color."

"...that would have been a better thing to say than making her think of her nose."

"Who's side are you on?"

Adora hadn't replied, and the rest of the drive had been in silence. She bit her lip. Things should be more okay by now. Finn was doing good, much better than before. They had Adora back in their lives, *She* had Adora back. She *had* missed her, all cursing and anger be damned. And now she was back. And damn it, she

was going to keep her! If they were in for take 2, this time it was for life. And it was going to be perfect. Okay, so they were taking it slow. Good. Nothing physical save for kisses and hugs. Good.

Catra knew that Adora was terrified she would make a mistake. Not that she had said so, Catra just knew. Okay, they had been married with all the intimate knowledge that comes with that , but Catra had known Adora to be a worrier long before. However, if Adora was worried about herself making the mistake, Catra was terrified *she* would let *Adora* think she made a mistake. She *had* to make sure Adora understood how determined she was. To show her how much she loved her, that her heart was true. To show the world how much she loved this girl.

She began to slowly sing to herself.

"It's a messed up worn-out fairytale

So why is it we still pretend?

When we both can say there's just no way

That this could have a happy end…"

The old punk song gave way to memories of happier days when there had been no Mrs and mrs. Just Catra and Adora. And Bow. And Flimmer.

Glimmer.

As she sat there in the faint green light, the solution struck her like lightning. And she frowned at the thought.

That's *the solution? Oh fuck me.*

As she returned downstairs, Adora waited at the door.

"I gave her an extra dollar. She said no when Finn wanted to watch Alien."

Catra rolled her eyes but smiled.

"So, good night?"

Adora leaned down, with a slight trepidation to give Catra a kiss. But since Catra had decided that she wasn't going to let her mood ruin the ending of the evening, she returned the kiss with interest and there they stood until it got embarrassing not to move further into another room. Or go home. In the end it was Catra that said it.

"Good night, Adora."

"Good night, Catra. ...I, *I,* had a great time tonight."

"It had it's good sides." She smirked. "It's not like I like you or anything. It's just nice to be with someone at times. Company."

"You enjoy my company?"

"Don't get excited. I said: 'being with *someone'.* Could have been anyone."

"For me being anyone, you're standing awfully close."

"Mhm. Is that a problem?"

"...No…"

They kissed again. Adora had her arms tight around Catra, her own grip of Adora being slight looser. Half-lidded eyes, looking deep into the others. half-opened mouths. Hearts beating faster. Hands ready to move further down. *If the question comes up I will say yes.* Catra could read Adora's face as easily as the newspaper and a big part of her wanted to just pull her over to

the couch. But a bigger part said *not when you're in the wrong type of mood.*

I'm not *in a* mood! *We just made out.* Sloppy *.*

Yeah, purer signs of denial has yet to be seen.

It was hard for Catra to break the spell when Adora was right in front of her, looking like *that.* But the slight disturbance in the feels had stuck, and now it grew. Finally she let the unthought question out.

...Moving too fast?

Yeah, sorta.

Mmkay.

So when Adora said, "...I could stay but…" Catra replied, "...but you have court tomorrow.”

Catra could see the interesting mix of disappointment and relief in Adoras eyes. She was silent for a second, collecting her thoughts perhaps.

"I need to be up early to prepare." She added.

"And you don't want to disturb us. Very thoughtful. " Catra replied, trying to sound like she really meant it.

"Yes."

Another kiss later and she was out.

Catra stood there and stared at the door. She slowly began to turn around. She walked through the rooms, checking if something needed to be done, turned the lights off, and went to the kitchen. There was a bottle of wine in the refrigerator. She liked her wine ice cold, even if she knew that wasn't exactly kosher. She wasn't going to open it now anyway.

I could *have asked her to stay. I* should *have asked her to stay. And really, why THE FUCK didn't I? She is already here every weekend, looking after Finn. She has a toothbrush here. We could have shared a glass and fallen asleep on the couch, watching some bad late night movie.*

...or we could have been in the bedroom.

A dry smile played on Catra's lips. *Oh god what a face Mara made when she suggested Finn could stay with them tonight… dirty old woman! Get your own action!* She made a grimace. *...Considering Hope she probably does.*

She poured herself a glass of milk while she answered the question she hadn't asked.

But yeah. It would be too easy. We have done easy. I need to show Adora that I am serious about us in another way.

She took her glass, went to her room, undressed, put on a t-shirt and a pair of sweatpants. She folded her pantsuit neatly for the next time she would wear it, returned to the kitchen where she swore over the lack of cookies and went for the couch. She turned on the TV and after a quick scroll, decided that watching Steven Seagal look constipated was stupid enough to fall asleep to. She drank her milk as he beat up 14 random thugs. Then she turned the TV off and sighed.

Okay. If that's what it takes… I have to do this.

She took up her phone and made a text. The main reason for Glimmer to visit Brightmoon was 'a damn conference', that she had bitched quite a great deal about how much she wanted to get out of it. She was probably still awake, preparing (and/or emptying the minibar...) and definitely cursing her way through it. Which meant there was a good chance she would take the chance, even with her...

Whatup sparkles? Busy tomorrow?

Sparkles

Why are YOU asking? Adora forced you to make nice?

She made a face and began to write an appropriate answer but stopped, erased it, and began again.

No, I just want to talk.

A long time passed.

Sparkles

YOU want to talk… you know what. I want to skip tomorrow's meeting anyway. Buy me lunch and I will come.

Do I look like I can afford to buy you lunch?

Sparkles

Since when is McDonalds expensive?

Catra bit back another knee-jerk reaction.

5th avenue. 11.15. No plus menu though

Sparkles

Sundaes or we're off.

Alright. I probably have a coupon. C u 2morrow

Sparkles

yeah

She looked at her phone. Then she threw it on the carpet and decided that the sofa was good enough for tonight. She stared up at the roof. Why Glimmer… Arrowman was so much easier. He was friendly and he could be fun at times, even if he was as vanilla as they came. But she had decided she had been done with easy, Arrowman was the very definition of easy. He'd always gave Catra the benefit of the doubt back then and when they had met for the first time in years a few months back, he had apologized so damn much for not knowing about the divorce, and not being there for her as well that Catra had blushed. Damn, he had called HER a few times since Adora returned to her life big time. Yep, exactly the same ol' Bow. Befriending Bow was easy. It was practically already done. She knew that. Adora knew that. There was no challenge there. Befriending Glimmer would show Adora how much Catra cared. How much she invested. She knew she needed to. She knew she HAD to. There was just one slight problem.

She completely and thoroughly hated Glimmer's guts.

"You better be worth this, Adora" she murmured before drifting off to sleep.

***

She isn't worth it. No one is worth this.

Catra glared at Glimmer. Glimmer in her turn, had spent the majority of their shared time glaring at Catra. They had met up at McDonalds, debated over which place had the best fries and ended up on House of Pancakes. It wasn't something she wanted Glimmer to know (just yet, maybe not even at all) but she reluctantly admitted she knew the manager and had a discount based on old comradeship and maybe a humble threat of violence. *Violence? Yeah. Lashor is a wuss.* Glimmer had commented with a snide smile that this more than once must have been the quick-fix anytime she needed to cheer Finn up.

Again, Catra had to reluctantly agree. It was cheap, but a big stack of pancakes with Maple Syrup and Butter made up for almost everything. Not that she was the only one, she knew that this was an essential part of the forgiveness process for Finn when Adora had fucked up her schedule. Glimmer maybe knew, but probably chose to ignore it.

"You go here often then." The remark had been said with a soft voice and a sweet smile. But she knew what it meant. Catra was the bad guy. End of story.

I bet you use this to your advantage everytime you want Finn to be on your side as well. was probably what she wanted to say. Catra took a deep breath. Okay, maybe she was reading too much

into Glimmer's eyes but… dammit, did she *have* to look at Catra *that way?*

Oh, Glimmer knew that Catra didn't like her well, and Catra was... pretty sure the feeling was completely mutual. She was regretting this hard. Back in the days of the roaring 20's when they were the BFS and did all shit together… There had always been a tolerance. Just tolerance. Back in the days. But now they were adults, supposed to do this the adulty way. Civil. polite. No safety nets. No drinks, no movie, no activities to keep the conversation rolling. No Bow, always ready with a distraction. And more than anything else, no *Adora* , half-giggling, half annoyed ejaculating 'you two are the worst' after any passive-aggrecsssive or half-posinous remark which would disarm any brooding conflict. Nope. Just middle aged Catra and Glimmer and to be honest… They were both simply too old to give a fuck. Glimmer probably had agreed to come because a free lunch was free lunch. And it had been clear from the start that *she* wasn't going to make it less awkward. Catra was still only half-way through her plate (blueberry pancakes with compote) while Glimmer had devoured her New York Cheesecake pancakes. With Cream. Catra knew how rich it was and it did take determination to eat it. *When the enemy is paying I suppose...* The silence was thick as the cream and jam mashed together. They had a table near the window, an old trick she had learned from an old friend. If conversation went bland, one could always look out the window and say something like "WOW, look at that FAT BITCH!" or "Hey! The ghost of Joe Biden just passed on a bike!" Catras examples. Still valid.

Today, however, the most exciting thing was a non-figurative person in a long wide coat standing on the pavement staring at nothing and everything. Not even the liquor store or the barbershop on the opposite side attracted enough people to be interesting. She did argue with herself whether the person in the coat was a woman or a man, but that was digging deep if she was

to bring that up. *And she doesn't care that I think it looks like P… She doesn't even know who that is.* Lack of subjects be damned, it was fairly obvious that she had to be the first to speak. Dammit, she had to say *something* , she had taken the initiative!

“So, Sparkles…”

"Is it possible for you to use my real name *once?* Just once, it would have been nice. I can write it down for you, if you can’t remember."

Catra bit her lip. Okay. Having an agenda here. Polite. Civil. Trying to make amends.

"So, *Glimmer...* " the bite in her voice came way too effortlessly and Glimmer rolled her eyes in perfect sync.

"Wow. Applause. Want a cookie? What are you going to say now? If you’re going to ask if I have read any good books lately, I am leaving this instant.” Her whole body screamed *Work for it, bitch.*

Catra scowled, but managed a comeback.

“I was going to ask your opinion on the situation in Afghanistan, actually.”

“Oh really?”

Catra gave Glimmer a long look. “Of course not! I was just hoping we could… I dunno… Talk.”

“Talk.”

“That’s what I said.” Catra muttered. There was silence.

“You want to talk. You.” Glimmer gave Catra a weird look, hostility mixed with... oh whatever. Catra had to sit on her hands not to squirm in her seat. In the end, she chose to talk back.

“Why are you looking at me like that?"

"Like what?"

"Stop being… Glimmer, you look at me like I, I dunno, delivered the savior to the filisteens or something. "

Glimmer looked at her hands. Then at the waiter, and then at Catra.

"I never liked you, to be honest."

Wow. That was direct. Catra wasn’t sure, but it kinda looked like Glimmer had managed to surprise herself.

"Yeah, I said it. You can take it."

So, no apology for being rude. Okay then. I can take it. Adult. That’s me. Catra was silent and Glimmer continued after a second.

"Back then, it was me and Adora and Bow. Just us. It was fine. Perfectly fine. And then *you* came along, first as Adoras old pal from elementary. Then BFF. Then her *girlfriend* . Then her *wife* . During those years, if you wanted Adora, you got Catra as well. That was the deal."

The waiter had come to their table now and asked if they wanted something more. Glimmer asked for more coffee. Catra felt that she needed a beer but she had to settle for coffee. She asked for a refill as wellhead, he bowed and returned with the container to do his duty. Catra looked away. Staring at someone pouring coffee? Not that trope today. Out on the street, the person in the coat had removed the hood to reveal long brown hair. Probably a woman, if the usage of conditioner was to be taken as evidence. Catra froze slightly. *Shit. It really looks like P… But it can’t be…* Glimmer continued once the waiter had left them.

"But that was okay. We liked Adora. You… honestly, I thought you were just a booty call after that first time. And I mean You're, You're hot. But you're also..."

"You think I was hot?" *Well done brain...*

"Um...Yes. I do? You still are, a bit more on the milf side but that's natural. Okay, probably shouldn't have said that. That was rude of me. So… well, your personality, it is… interesting. "

Catra splayed her arms.

"You're unbelievable! First you call me hot, and sure, thanks I know I am, good catch -still overstepping it by a mile, but then, then, you call my personality *interesting?* That's… That's… Like, you could just straight out call me a bitch!"

"Please. Calling YOU a bitch would be a compliment!" Glimmer took a sip of her coffee. "This place has great coffee. Black and dark like your soul."

Catra's eyes shot arrows. "Why are you being so damn mean?"

Glimmer's eyes didn't shoot back. They got hard as diamonds. "Because, Catra. Bow thinks it's great that the two of you are back together. I don't. I am old enough to not waste time on being polite. I think it's a mistake and I want the both of you to know it. You're bad for Adora. Period."

Catra bit her lip. It was obvious that she was not going to cry. Not that she had anything better to do, though, she had nothing to say. Partly because she *was* hurt, but also because that was exactly what she would have said herself if she was in Glimmer's situation. Perhaps with a few more 'fuck's but… In the back of her mind she could hear Adora. " *The two of you are very alike. I don't understand why you can't get along, you have so much in common!* "

A mutual hate for each other isn't really something I would call 'in common', Adora…

She decided to once again look out the window. Just to look at something else...

Outside the window, the figure turned their head, to reveal a slightly dirty but cute face. Cute nose, kind, but tired eyes. Dark eyes. Freckles. Catra froze in her seat. *Fuck me, those eyes! Damn, it really looks like… but it can't be… it can't be her…* Glimmer was now looking in the same direction as Catra, eyeing the person up and down and made a look of disgust that probably meant *Figures Catra knows someone like that.* Catra instantly looked back at Glimmer. She opened her mouth. "Now, look here, *Glimmer!* I…"

The world would never learn if she was going to mend something or just completely destroy everything, Catra wasn't sure herself. The reply on her tongue never came out, since the person outside first put on a red ski mask, then produced a revolver from a pocket, crossed the road and went into the liquor store.

Catra half-rose in her seat. "Glimmer! Did you see that!?"

Glimmer frowned. "Yeah, why the heck would you wear a ski mask in the middle of town?"

"Are you that stupid or are you just pretending? She had a gun, Glimmer! She's gonna rob the liquor store!"

"WHAT THE …?"

Whit Catra was frozen, standing in her seat, staring at the street, Glimmer produced her cellphone and rang.

"911? Yes, I want to report a ongoing robbery. On Evergreen Street, a liquor store. Sorry? I am not sure… one person, masked, armed. My name? Glimmer. Oh, no problem, I… WHAT THE HELL?"

Catra had snatched the phone from Glimmer's hand and ended the phonecall.

"Gimme my phone! What do you think you're doing?"

"What *I* am doing? What are *you* doing?"

"Calling 911, doing my duty as a citizen?" Glimmer gave Catra a duh-look.

"Are you nuts!? We can't get involved in this!"

"We're not getting involved! That's why I called the police, DUMBO!"

Catra pinched her nose. "For fuck's ache, Glimmer! I saw her! *You* saw her! We are witnesses! We will be called in to testify!"

Glimmer slowly tilted her head. "And that's a bad thing because…?"

"I don't want to testify! I don't want anything to do with the cops!" Catra began to throw her arms around in excitement. Glimmer rose up to Catra's face.

"You're dating a *lawyer* ."

There was a pause. "Yeah, so?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes, "Doesn't that make you something of a hypocrite?"

"Doesn't your voice give you a headache?" Catra's eyes shot flames now.

At that moment, two gunshots were heard, dulled by the glass, but unmistakably gunshots. Both women ducked instinctively. No bullets were flying through the window though, and no more shots were fired. Slowly they eased themselves up to a pending upright position as they stared into the street, waiting for the next

move. It didn't take long. Suddenly the robber, still wearing the mask, rushed out and disappeared from view briefly. The mask concealed the face, but the long brown hair was all too visible from the neck and further down. Glimmer noticed how it flowed in the wind as the robber ran by. Then there was a sound of a roaring engine and the robber rushed by on a motorbike seconds later.

Catra felt herself going cold again. She rose and put on her jacket.

"Shit. I need to go."

"No you don’t!”

“Yes, I am! Now let go of me!”

“I’m not even holding you! Your jacket is stuck on the chair! And we’re not done talking! Besides, I'm not taking the bill! And why? You said you didn't want to be involved!"

Catra glared at Glimmer, and pulled her jacket free. "Lashor gives me credit, no worries, You don't have to bring out the piggy bank for me, Sparkles. And I… Don't think I have a choice."

"What?"

"I know the robber."

"What?"

"Yeah. It's fucked up. I need to talk to Scorpia."

End of part one.

Lock, stock and two fresh batches of biscuits

Glimmer stared at the now empty street while Catra threw a few dollars on the waiter and screamed "Rest is on my tab!" Then she ran out in the street. Glimmer was still inside, seeing through the window how the owner of the liquor store stepped outside his shop. Shocked, of course, and screaming because also of course! But alive and not hurt. Thank God. And there was Catra, in the same spot the robber had been just before. It looked like she was searching for a cab. Glimmer rose, put another bill on the table, ran out and caught up with Catra.

"Where are we going?"

"*We* are not going anywhere, Sparkles. "

"Oh yes we are!" Glimmer whistled, and a cab stopped next to them. " Now get in and tell the driver where we're going." Catra stayed outside the cab for a few seconds, staring at the closed door with a look of “WTF?” Then she went around, sat down in the back seat, muttered the address to the driver and moved as fast away from Glimmer as she could.
She proceeded being silent, leaving Glimmer sparkling with questions but she stayed silent. It wasn't easy, there were so many questions… One very distinct part of Glimmer's personality was how she was able to switch from cheerful to angry back to cheerful within seconds and when even her *very diplomatic* bff turned fiance once had mentioned that she might be a bit… hard to read.. she had to admit it could be a problem. So she stayed silent. And she new well enough that being confrontational never worked with Catra.

Catra didn’t say a word either. Not to her, not to the driver. She hadn’t even given him a proper adress. Just “Fright Zone. Somewhere in the middle.” She hadn’t even glared at her. She had more or less been staring at her own feet the whole time. What was her deal?
The taxi drove through downtown Brightmoon, passed the newly

gentrified blocks of the New Spire (The old spire being a huge industry complex, now more or less covered in trees and bushes and turned into a green lollipop paradise) and crossed the river Drylstream before reaching the suburb of Arachnia, a collection of boxes that a few people without shame called blocks of flats. The general look of decay and criminality numbers had given it the nickname "the fright zone" something that still clinged on even after it had cooled down significantly in the latest years. Even a few of the glossier magazines had started to write about the raw clubs and venues, so it would probably not belong before the first Starbucks came.

Glimmer tried to understand Catra. Was she tolerating her in hope that she would get killed by the robber? Or at least hurt? Or was she actually being sincere with her wish to know her better? Both options was equally possible. Especially since Catra still hadn't said anything. Glimmer frowned and looked out the window.

Had it been me, I would have thrown her out of the taxi. Then she sighed and closed her eyes.

So why did I insist of joining her then… She opened her eyes and looked at the drivers neck for a few blocks.

Because I...

"What number did you say again, miss?" The driver spoke for the first time and broke the silence.

Catra muttered, "I didn't. But we're going to number 164B."

"Right on."

Glimmer looked at her and managed to catch Catras eye. She in turn glared back at Glimmer. "Think this is fun, Sparkles?"

"Extremely. So, this Scorpia is the robber?"

Catra looked up. "What? No! Scorpia couldn't hurt a fly!" She seemed to be genuinely upset. "What makes you say that?"

"Oh, I don’t know, perhaps the fact that you haven't told me ANYTHING since we got into the cab. I had to draw my own conclusions. And!" She added before Catra could protest, "You have to admit, chasing a robber? Into the fright zone? That's so much a cliche it hurts."

Catra bit her lip. "Point. Okay. So, No. Scorpia is not the robber. She's probably the most honest person I know… who ever got caught for possession."

"What?"

“And carrying an illegal firearm. Being complacent in a crime. Protecting a criminal. And Jaywalking.”

“Okay, now I KNOW you’re messing with me.”

“Am I? Heh.”

Catra looked away. Okay, so Glimmer had to work for it. She opened her mouth to say something, but that moment the cab stopped and they had to get out. Without asking Catra, Glimmer paid and left a decent tip.

"That's a fucking fortune you tipped that guy with!" Catra muttered again.

"It's the surest way to make sure the driver will remember us in case of a potential kidnapping or something. I learned my lesson after Huntara."

“Oh my. What an adventure. What experience you have of life.”

“HEY! We almost got killed!”

"Whatever." Catra turned her back to Glimmer and began to move towards the door. The complex was huge, old and painted in a sick nuance of pink for some reason. Everywhere there were similar buildings,everything was concrete, steel and asphalt, save for the sparse tree or a lone bush. On the corner was a neon sign

showing the way to the local bar "Black garnet Saloon". It even smelled of bad Country and western. Catra had already opened the door and was about to head into the gateway of complex 165 b when Glimmer caught her arm and stopped her.

"Hey!"

"Catra, I am not going in there without more info. And I don’t think you should either. And also, from the little I heard in the cab, there's a story behind this."

Catra tore herself away from Glimmer. "It's not like you had to come with me anyway." Then she added under her breath, "For the love of Christ, why couldn't it have been Adora?"

Glimmer replied immediately. "Because Adora would never have let you. Lawyer shit "stay out of trouble."

Catra looked at the street. Finally she muttered, "I didn't ask for your opinion. It would have been much better if I had been alone."

"Oh? How would you have paid for the cab then? And four arms fight better than one!"

Catra glared at Glimmer again. Then she shook her head and said, "Alright, now listen here, Sparkles! 1. You can stay outside. I didn't ask you to come! And I could have paid, thank you very much!. 2. So? You still hate my guts. "

"Do you really think I am going to let you confront an armed criminal on your own?"

"Yes!" Catra gave Glimmer a look of surprise. "You just told me how much you despise me! Let me get killed, like you care!"

Glimmer grabbed Catras arm. "Listen, you twat. Maybe I think you're the biggest insult to humankind there is. But you're also Finn's mother. I care about them and I don't want them to grow

up without a parent.” She paused, and had her face inches away from Catras, “No matter how degenerated she is."

Then she backed away and waited. Catra was silent so she kept talking herself.

"Now, 1. No one tells me what to do. Not even Bow and especially not when you think! 2. Still going to stop Finn's mom from getting killed. And 3.”

“I didn’t have three.”

“I do. Gotta one up you. 3. Firearms? Protecting criminals? I don’t buy she’s not the one you saw. “

"See for yourself then." Catra shrugged her shoulders and went inside. Glimmer cursed, but followed.

***

Okay. Unless we're in some veeeery weird episode of the Twilight Zone or the X-files with shapeshifters, this is definitely NOT the one Catra saw. That We saw.

The woman in the doorway was the biggest and largest person she had seen, including Huntara. Her mom had once had a bodyguard that was… Well, equal in length. But Juliet had nothing on this girl's muscle mass. If Juliet was a precise weapon, this was a tank. All muscle and a haircut that equally screamed “Queer” and “Got fists, will fight.” She had to be Catra’s age, so she assumed that this was an OLD friend, pre-adora even, maybe. But the only thing showing her age was some grey strokes in the otherwise white hair and Glimmer caught herself feeling jealous. *So maybe I should work-out a bit more…* She shook her head. *later*. Scorpia also wore an apron with a roller and the text “They see me rollin they hatin’” Not to mention that her eyes were as friendly as Bow’s and THAT was saying something. Glimmer had no idea what to say, she couldn’t even process the fact that Catra was being lifted up and violently hugged which greatly discomforted her.

This has to be an pulp fiction-Au of Winnie the pooh.

“And who is this? Is it your ex? Wife? Ex-wife? Ex-wife-turned-girlfriend? Bird you picked up at the pub?” aaaand she's British.

“No, this is Glimmer.”

"Glimmer."

"Yes, Scorpia. Glimmer. Do you want me to write it d… She’s one of Adoras friends, okay? The most annoying one of them."

“Aaaah! Figures she's not a date, cause she’s waaay out of your league, mate."

"She’s not… Scorpia!"

"Face it, wild cat! She looks like a million pounds and you don't! She also looks like someone who would love some of me chocolate biscuits, and you hate my chocolate biscuits. Which reminds me, let me get some!" She left, leaving the door open. Catra sighed and entered the flat. Glimmer followed, if nothing else because chocolate biscuits sounded nice.

Once inside, they found themselves in a room that one or two designers she knew would kill to get their hands on. It was a messy blend of bad maintenance, old furniture, brand new Ikea-stuff and flowers oh so many flowers. It was one of those rooms that didn't make sense and yet you could not see another alternative on how to decorate it.

Catra looked equally at home and disturbed.

"Okay, wanna tell me what this is about now?"

"No."

"...You do understand that I will hear it anyway once Scorpia returns."

Catra looked like she was arguing with herself.

"Eh. Figure it out yourself."

Glimmer frowned. "Why are you such a nightmare?"

"Years and years of practice."

It was at that moment Scorpia re-entered the room, apron off but with a few spots of flour on her clothes. with a plate full of cookies and three mugs.

"Hullo hullo hullo! Always nice to meet new people. Hope you will enjoy them, Glimmer, right? That is your real name? The biscuits are free from weed, btw and if they aren't I am going to have a SERIOUS talk with someone. Now, I hope you don't mind herbal tea. That's all we have anyway since we forgot to go shopping yesterday so it's either that or hot water with sugar."

Glimmer replied that it was not a problem and proceeded to grab a cookie. It was still warm from the oven and slightly massive but the rich taste sure made up for that!

"Tish is great!"

"Didn’t mommy teach you not to talk with food in your mouth?" Catra sneered at her, as she very carefully took a cookie and began to eat it.

"Now now, wildcat. Everyone isn't as well-mannered as you."

"True. I suppose I should cut her some slack, she's a rich kid after all." Catra dried her hands on a napkin, as she gave Glimmer a quick glance.

"Hey!"

"Manners, wild cat! So, what brings you here?"

Catra leaned forward with a serious face Glimmer hadn't seen before.

" Scorp, I have bad news… It’s about Perfuma."

Scorpia made big eyes and lifted her ginormous hands to her mouth. Glimmer had to suppress a laugh. The gesture was out of genuine worry, but it looked like it was taken out of a comic book. The whole of Scorpia was surreal.

Give her a different pair of eyes and she would have been a perfect villain in Game of thrones…

"No! It can't!"

"Yes. I saw her. She….she robbed a liquor store."

"No! Chimney Crickets! I can't have another felony on me or me license will be invoked!"

Glimmer couldn’t stop herself from asking. "Another felony?"

Scorpia blushed. "Yeah… I did six months last year. I actually got one year so I am out on probation."

"For what?"

"Resistance." Glimmer wanted to ask but the words didn’t want to take shape. She picked up another cake just to have something to do. However, Catra apparently found an explanation necessary.

"Scorpia beat up two cops that were trying to capture a bag-snatcher."

"...Why did you do that?" Glimmer stared at Scorpia, third cookie halfway to her mouth.

"I don't approve of fascist pig brutality. Also, it was my niece."

Never get on this girl's bad side… "Okay, just a moment. I have a ton of questions but let's leave most of them for now. Who is

Perfuma? Is that even a name?"

"It's my wife. And of course it's a name!"

"It's...uncommon."

"It's unique! Just like her…" Scorpia got something dreamy in her eyes.

"Scorp, focus! We need to help her, and help you, if you need to stay clean." Catra leaned forward, she looked more serious and focused than ever, but Glimmer could hold back another question.

"Why would someone named ‘Perfuma' rob a liquor store? A private crusade against alcohol?"

Scorpia whistled. "Lucky for you she isn't here! She would jump on to that idea in a blink!"

Glimmer blinked. "...Is she some kind of eco terrorist?"

"No!"/"Sort off."

Scorpia and Catra replied simultaneously. Scorpia looked at Catra with hurt in her eyes, Catra just rolled her eyes.

"She’s not! That’s just plain rude!"

"Scorp, she set fire to McDonald's in Salinaeas."

"She had her reasons!"

Glimmer began to understand why Catra had described Scorpia the way she did.

"Can you take it from the beginning? If she is an arsonist, she is dangerous!"

"She’s not dangerous! She's just… very passionate about her heart issues."

Scorpia paused. Glimmer stared and Catra rolled her eyes again. Scorpia proceeded, calmer now.

"Okay… so. She runs an ecological, holistic, vegan grocery store up in Plumeria."

"That sounds...does it run well?" Glimmer, always the business woman, had to know.

"You see how and where we live, right? Bees and honey don’t grow on trees." Glimmer opemed her mouth, closed it, opened it again, then Catra interrupted.

"She means Money, Glitter. Anyway, Perfuma hates when animals and the environment gets hurt. And if you let her stew long enough she gets violent."

"Wild cat…" Scorpia shook her head. "If she gets to do her morning yoga and drink her tea in peace it's nothing. Then she can take all of existence's small soul-crushing disappointments calmly and direct her energy away from what she can't control to what she can do."

Glimmer bit down on another biscuit. Even if she had been with Scorpia for a max 20 minutes, she realized that that sentence was not her ordinary vocabulary but something she had been told many many many times.

"Aand when that goes wrong she immediately starts plotting for world domination. "

"Wildcat, for the love of saint Paul!"

"Scorpia, your wife is a lunatic!"

"She’s passionate!"

"...and you're in denial. Okay, doesn't matter. Point is, if she gets caught, you're both in trouble! We need to find her and get her away."

"Okay hold on hold on! Are you even sure it was her you saw?" Glimmer decided it was time to be the voice of reason. *Oh why didn't I bring Bow...*

"Of course I'm sure! Tall, slim, long brown hair… cute nose. Quivering lip when she thinks of all the puppies that get beaten."

Glimmer shot Catra a glance after the last sentence, but Scorpia reacted on another thing.

"Now wait a moment! Perfuma has blond hair!"

"That did throw me off, but it was her face alright!"

Glimmer pinched her nose. "Look, this sounds like pure overreacting! The hair is quite a big part of a person, and if you got that wrong you probably mistook yourself."

"I did not! It was her!"

"In brown hair and a dirty coat? Yeah sure it was her!"

"Ah! It could be a disguise!" Scorpia exclaimed.

"Don't encourage her!" Glimmer replied.

"She knows I'm right!"

"Look! Before you two get all worked up, there is a simple solution that will probably put an end to all of this! Scorpia, your wife has a cell-phone, right? Can't you just call her?"

"Like she would be honest about that…" Catra crossed her arms but Scorpia's face lit up. "Of course! If I ask her, she will tell the truth! She never lies to me!"

Scorpia produced a cell-phone and rang a number. She put it on speaker and held it out so they all would hear.

Five signals rang before a high pitched voice answered it did sound a bit stressed.

"Hi sweetie! What's up?"

"Hello luv! It's Scorpia." A second of silence.

"Yes, I see that it’s you." The voice was cheerful but there was a touch of strain in it. "What's the matter? I am in a bit of a hurry now so please be quick."

"Oh. Well… we… I was just wondering… what you were up to."

There was a pause. Glimmer didn’t like that pause. "Oh. Well… you see... I had to take care of something. "

"Oh. Take care of what?"

"Oh, nothing special. Just something I needed to fix. Business."

Was Glimmer wrong or was there a slight tension in the remarkably sweet and calm voice?

"Dear. I need to ask you a question and I need you to be honest. Did you do something illegal today?"
Perfuma was silent. Catra shook her head slowly as she muttered something and Glimmer found herself with her mouth wide open. But Scorpias face was completely open, to her that was the best question to ask. She really is something else...
Then Perfumas voice returned, with a lot of uncertainty in it.

"Well…" But whatever that was to follow was lost in the sudden noise. Screaming breaks, a loud bang, metal scrapes and sirens. A cacophony rang from the phone and excited voices of which some absolutely not was Perfumas could be heard, including a 'HANDS WHERE I CAN SEE THEM!'

"I...need to hang up. Talktoyoulateraeeyouatdinnerbye."

Call ended.

The three women looked at each other. Then they rose at the same time.

"Cab?"

"Already on it."

"No need for that. We can take the crawler!"

"The WHAT?"

Glimmer looked at Scorpia, mouth agape. She saw Catra smirk at her.

"Yeah, you are in for a RIDE, Sparkles"

Goin' up the country



Glimmer was the first one out back on the street, with Catra not far behind. Scorpia was somewhere in the apartment, shouting something about 'keys' after them. Catra who knew Scorpia wanted to stay behind to help her friend, or rather make sure she actually got out of the apartment, but Glimmer insisted on her standing alone on a street in ARACHNIA was placing a sign with

"rob me" on her. Catra had to agree she had a point, as gentrified the area was becoming, it wasn't THAT friendly yet.

The same cab that took Catra and Glimmer there was still waiting outside. Glimmer looked surprised, but Catra only shrugged her shoulders when she saw it. *Yeah, Glimmer, a hefty tip will not only make him remember you, it will also lead to him lurking outside in wait for crazy rich lady who tips too much to go home again.* It was, as always, fun to see the hope die in some loser geezer's eyes, even if it wasn't she who did it and it wasn't an invite.

Scorpia was the last one out, wearing two huge gloves. Even with winter around, they looked enormous, which was a feat on such a huge person. It gave her an even bigger impression of a scorpion than before. Catra made a face.

“So lassies! Are you ready to rumble!?”

“Less talking, more driving! Where is the car?” *Glitter is eager, hmm? We’ll see how long that will last…*

“Oh, it’s over here in the garage! Just follow me!”

Glimmer gave Catra a questioning look, Catra just shrugged her shoulders and followed Scorpia. It turned out to be quite a walk, five minutes in, and they didn’t seem to be any closer.

“Catra…?”

“Yeah, Sparkles?”

“Can you please… Oh whatever. We have passed three garages already! What kind of car does she have? And why can’t she keep it on the street like normal people?”

“Normal is only a word that exists on a tumble dryer, Sparkles.”

Glimmer frowned. “Don’t try to pull a woke-card on me. Bisexual polyamorous half-korean here. You know what I mean.”

Catra bit her lip. Why was she still trying to hold back?

“Well, maybe YOUR normal isn’t the same as ordinary working class-queer Normal, MISS C.E.O!”

Catra felt a mixed feeling in her gut. The shot had hit bullseye, Catra always had an idea that Glimmer hated to be reminded of how privileged she was, and it got confirmed in this very moment by the color that shot up in Glimmer's face. Some part of her scolded her, but she didn’t care. *So what if she hates me more…* Glimmer opened her mouth, apparently a row was about to break out.

“Alright, listen here, you…”

“We’re here!”Scorpia’s cheerful voice cut through their argument and Catra found Glimmer staring in genuine surprise at the building they were outside. She had seen it before, but the building was still a sight to see. It was a garage alright, but the kind that fixed cars. ‘Grizzlor and suns, 24 hour service.’ Under the old, but surprisingly tidy neon sign was a couple of handcrafted signs.

‘Ask about our low prices, but don’t expect us to answer.’

‘If you didn’t buy it here, don’t come here complaining about your lousy car.’

‘No service during lunch and dinner. No means no.’

Scorpia had already entered through the front door. Catra was to follow, but Glimmer was frozen. She splayed her arms in the same surprise as before. “THIS is where she keeps her car?”

“Not really, she has a parking space right in front of the house, but there is usually something that breaks after every time she uses the car so she more or less keeps it here all the time. She’s the sole reason ‘surveillance’ is part of their service.”

“Every...time?”

“She did say the car was British, right? Brits can’t make cars if their life depends on it. Now let's go inside. It’s cold.”

But neither of them could move before the left gate opened and a huge vehicle rolled out, under a roar and squealing making it sound like an old bear coming out of hibernation. Glimmer stared, again. *If she keeps staring like that, her eyes will get stuck that way…*

“THIS is the car?” They found themselves outside a big, scruffy army vehicle. It looked a bit like those armored trucks that came to one of her offices to pick up valuables, but this one had more steel plates and reinforced windows and door. It also looked like it had been driven through at least five deserts without any repairs. A hatch on the top opened and a huge hairy man climbed out. “Just the regular fee for having it here, you get the oil refill free this time.”

“Thank you, Grizz!”

“Eh, it’s just a little gift to my best customer! Thanks to you, we could renovate the whole of the staff areas this summer! If you keep bringing this baby in, we can pay for that new lift by march!”

“That’s great news! Thank you, Grizz!”

“You’re welcome! Well, galpals? Isn’t she a beauty? I call her called ‘the crawler!’ I got it from me mum!”

Catra smirked. Glimmer probably tried her best to not look terrified, she was happy if she managed to pull off ‘polite’. “...Did she...serve in the army?” Scorpia laughed and shook her head.

“No, no! She was a peace activist! She stole this from a depot somewhere in Devon to impress mom. Back then it used to have a machine gun attached to the roof as well! Ah… all the summer holidays we spent in this beauty…”

“Did you go on holiday in THIS?” Okay, now her eyes had to be hurting for real.

Scorpia looked at Glimmer and raised her eyebrows. “Of course! It’s a perfect family car! It has four bunks and enough storage space to let you survive a week of surveillance fire without leaving.” She paused. “Not that we ever had to live through that. Mum was a lover, not a fighter. Which reminds me, the suspencion is GREAT! It’s like driving a boat on land.”

“Wow. I can’t wait to get inside…”

“Glad you like it! Now hop in! The quicker we get to Perfuma, the better!”

Glimmer did what every newbie did looking at the Crawler, she began to search for a door. Catra, who had seen both the look and the car before, grabbed her arm. “The door is on the backside, Sparkles.”

“Oh. Where… did Scorpia go?”

“She climbed in through the hatch in the roof. That’s the only way to get into the driver seat. Get in and make yourself comfortable. And grab a pair of earplugs.”

“That loud?”

“Mostly the transmission.” When she noticed Glimmer still standing on the street, she rolled her eyes. “Look, not everyone can afford a Porsche or a Königsegg. Get over your prejudice and get in.”

***

Great news that the money you spend… Glimmer made a mental note to check out what Mr. Grizzlor prized his services and to make sure Scorpia was compensated for this. Considering the outcome of their last adventure, this could end… interesting.

Glimmer clenched her fists, but she climbed in. Well inside, she had to admit that it was pretty cozy. There was a large space with four simple bunks along the sides that doubled as sleeping areas and seats. A large window separated the rear area from the driver's seat. The front window was barely visible behind the two seats and the snow had begun to fall making it hard to see anything through the windows other than a gray curtain.

"It's bulletproof and 4 inches thick. Scorpia won't hear us even if we knock so keep your phone up if you want to reach her," Catra said as she sat down on the left side.

There were a few, rather narrow windows on each side, which would barely let in any daylight under normal circumstances anyway, but the inside was pretty well illuminated from a row of lightbulbs in the roof, of which one was gone and one was flickering but not so much it was annoying. There were gaps and hatches everywhere, all neatly marked. “Fluids.” “Food” “fresh sheets.” “Dirty Sheets” “Fruit” “Emergency gardening tools.” “Weaponry.”

Glimmer's hand reached for the weaponry, but Catra stopped her. “The less you know about what’s inside this thing the better. Makes court hearings so much easier.”

Glimmer made a face. “How...do you know Scorpia?”

“Known her since we were teens.”

“She’s British.”

“Oh, you noticed that right now? Well done, Sherlock.” Once again that biting of the lip on Catra. Glimmer shrugged it off. Whatever her game was, she wasn’t going to deal with it now. She opened her mouth to tell Catra, and then Scorpia turned the engine on, effectively killing all kinds of conversation.

“CATRA!”

“WHAT?”

“I SAID, CATRA!”

“WHAT ARE YOU SAYING? I CAN’T HEAR A THING!”

Glimmer frowned, and produced her cell phone. She began to write.

You are a jerk.

She handed the phone to Catra who read it, gave Glimmer the raspberry and wrote something back, then she handed it over again.

And you are surprised? You don’t like me

I don't like plenty of people that aren't jerks.

Am I supposed to feel better by that?

It's 'is that supposed to make me feel better'

Are you the grammar squad now, Sparkles?

How do you know Scorpia?

Don't change the subject!

You know what I think about you. I don't want to waste more time on that. Tell me how you know this weird woman and her wife

Scorpia isn't weird!

Glimmer didn't write a response, she just looked at Catra and raised an eyebrow. Catra looked away and made a frowny face

Fuck you.

Glimmer still didn't reply.

...We met at a camp.

Military?

No… A reformation camp. A Christian camp with the end goal to turn queer kids straight.

Glimmer stared at Catra and she felt this reaction getting old. But how was she to show chock otherwise?

WHAT?

Catra grabbed the phone and began to write frantically.

It wasn't a violent camp with electric shocks and that nasty stuff!

Really

Really! It was way more… girl guide-y. We were supposed to learn to be good soldiers in the Christian army. To be good citizens.

Ooookay

You don't write four o's

I do what I want. Go on.

Catra rolled her eyes.

Well, it was homemade, hearty food. Lots of exercise and shit.

Sounds like Adora would have loved it.

When I told her she asked where she could apply.

…

Yeah.

Go on

Okay. Well, then there were prayers and Bible readings about how God created man and woman and all that. And we learned how to cook and how to build things and to operate tools and… heck, Scorpia learned how to drive a truck there.

She's that much older?

She was 19 when we met. I was 15.

Okay… did your mom send you there?

I don't have a mom.

Oh Catra I'm so sorry

Don't be. Orphanage. Gene cocktail. Mexican I think, maybe Paraguayan, perhaps brazilian and Polish. A touch of everything. Not important.

Catra, that is Catra ripped the phone from Glimmers hand.

Don't. Talk. About. It.

Glimmer had to hold back not to ask Catra anything. There was some story here, but she made it clear that it was a no-go zone. At Least she was willing to talk about how she met Scorpia. It was slightly weird, but it seemed like it was easier for Catra to talk about it while texting. Well Okay, she wasn't going to complain as long as it worked. So when Catra finally gave the phone back she took her time to formulate her reply. *Okay, so the matron of the orphanage sent you?*

No

Glimmer waited.

It was my idea…

What?

I didn't know what it was okay? It sounded cool to learn to use a drill and a plane in God's honor!

Jesus, catra.

Yep, he was there too.

Glimmer looked up to see Catra snicker. She rolled her eyes.

Anyway, matron knew. She agreed because she hoped it would help me become less of a tomboy.

And it backfired?

I used to use hardware stores as dating grounds, Glimmer. What do you *think?*

You're matron must have been so disappointed.

She was until I helped fix the leaking roof and get the water heater back online.

Okay. So, that's when you met Scorpia.

Yep.

And she was there because she needed to be brainwashed too?

NO, Sparkles. She was sent there by her parents as an agent to take the place down from the inside.

O Kay.

Catra rolled her eyes, Glimmer snickered.

Yeah. Didn't work out.

Because the camp was so effective?

Because Scorpia is scorpia. I tell you her American accent was the worst. I think it helped selling her in as someone in dire need of help though.

Ah

Yeah. Well, she loved it. The open air, getting to be outside, being social… She didn't have that many friends back home.

Really?

She can be...intense.

Glimmer had a remark coming, but she remembered the bear hug.

I.think I understand. So, she learned the same thing you did?

Nono, she can't understand something technical if her life depended on it. She stayed in the kitchen. Practically learned to be a professional chef in that summer.

Huh

Pride in the name.of love, Sparkles.

So you met at camp.

We shared bunks. It was befriend her or die.

I see

She was also in love with me.

Glimmer looked up at Catra, who once again looked away. The roar of the motor was now joined by Scorpia singing. It was impossible to hear what it was though. Glimmer wrote a reply.

That must have been fun.

Catra just sat with the phone in her hand for a while before she slowly wrote a reply.

I didn't understand what she was talking about until many years later. Honestly, there's no point in sending someone to a brainwashing anti-gay camp before they know they're queer.

Um…

Yeah. She was persistent on becoming my girlfriend… I thought friend.

Shit

That's what SHE said.

That's not funny.

No.Sparkles, that WAS what she said.

And your still friends.

Someone has to make sure she stays out of trouble.

I never heard of her while you and Adora was together.

She was back in England then. Taking care of things after her parents died.

Damn!

Yeah. They died for they beliefs.

...terrorist attack? Death by cop?

They wished. They were doing a hunger strike to stop the building of a motorway.

Does that kill you?

If you are in the wrong forest it does.

Damn.

Don't worry. Scorpia said they looked so happy when they found the bodies. They died in battle as they wanted. Scorpia inherited the Crawler, an estate in Surrey and about 7 million pounds.

WHAT

Her mum was the daughter of lord whatever.

And yet she still lives like this?

She use the money to keep the estate going and gives to charity. Spending money on herself isn't very Marxist.

… Glimmer had no reply to that, so she returned the phone with the screen blank.

I said I had to help her from doing something stupid, didn't I?

Glimmer's head spun from all she had learned. So, Scorpia WAS insane. However, there were more sides to Catra than she initially thought. She still was a jerk though. She was thinking how the conversation was going to proceed when, all of a sudden, the sound of the engine died down completely, replaced with extremely loud rock music.

"I don't want to change the world, I'm not looking for new england, I am looking for another girl

I don"

Then the song was silenced, and Scorpia spoke. "No panic guys! Just need to fill her up with some good old diesel! She's still running like a steady stud!"

"Studs are male, Scorpia."

"Yea, but then there wouldn't be any alliteration, would it!? Just stay put, I'll be right back."

They saw her climb out and jump down on the street. The sudden silence had taken Glimmer so much by surprise at first she wasn't sure she remembered how to talk at all. She opened and closed her mouth a few times but nothing seemed to come out.

"I'm doing this for Adora." Instead Catra was the first to speak.

"Figures."

"Hey! What was that?"

"I know you like me as much as I like you. I know Adora asked you to befriend me. Bless her heart, but… for someone as smart as her she can be really dumb."

"SHE'S NOT DUMB!"

Catra had risen from her seat and pointed a finger at Glimmer.

"She's the smartest and bravest person I know! Okay, she needs to work on her priorities, but if anyone calls her stupid, I will make them regret it! Even you. Is that understood, Sparkles?"

Glimmer had to admit, the fire in Catra's eyes was genuine. And the threat WAS real, and while she imagined she could probably take Catra in a one-and-one brawl, but not without casualties. And so, the experienced C.E.O, with thousands of council meetings behind her and who had seen everything from *succession*- cold passive aggressiveness to outright violence decided to go down another path. That, and she was surprised, but more pleasantly this time.

"You really love her."

"Of course. Anyone who doesn't is stupid." She paused. "She's a freaking goddess, Sparkles. I made the biggest damn mistake in my life when I divorced her and I am NOT going to do that again. So BITE ME, Sparkles. I'm in her life and that's where I'll stay."

Glimmer was silent. She could say something, but it looked like Catra actually had something on her mind, and she had learned one thing about Catra over this day. Force her to speak and you got nothing. Let her take it at her own speed and you got a novel. So she stayed silent.

"I want to… I NEED to show her that I'm committed, Glitter. I need to prove to her that… It's for real. It's us. It's… Catradora for ever."

"Okay."

"I don't need YOU'RE fucking approval, Glitter!"

Glimmer instantly shut up. Catra glared, but after a few more moments, she continued.

"I wanted to talk to you, because… You're her best friend. And a pain in my ass. But if I could show her that we could be friends… She would know."

Glimmer was still silent, but on the inside she was torn between giving Catra a hug and punching her in the gut.

"I would take down the moon for her. That's a bit too hard. Apparently, so is getting on your good side."

Glimmer wasn't torn anymore. Punching her gut it was. She arose as well. "Well, maybe if you stopped being such an obnoxious bitch at every moment, it wouldn't be so hard to like you! If you could possibly turn off that nasty comments generator that goes nonstop in your head and actually be. Nice. For once, it wouldn't be so hard!"

The space was a bit too narrow for an actual fight, but this felt pretty much like punching Catra so it had to do. Catra on her hand didn't look like she was going to hold back much longer.

"Oh, like YOU are some kind of saint! Oh, look at me, I am so rich I can buy Lake Ontario and here I am, slobbing out at the mobs

level, pretending to be like them!”

“You don’t know SHIT about me!”

“I know ENOUGH, Glimmer! How many companies do you own? I can tell you how many *I* own, *Glitter!* NADA! ZERO! NILL! I have a house, I have a kid, I have a w...GF. And I have a job. And THAT’S IT! You probably have more houses than you have panties."

Glimmer clenched her fists. She DID have more than one house *and* a personal assistant, but that was beside the point. The spark that was so close to igniting the fuse back at the garage had lit up again and *this* time it began to spark. She jumped Catra, and had she not been taken by surprise, Glimmer wouldn’t have brought her to the floor. She held Catra down by straddling her over her chest and she had her fist ready for the punch.

“You are NOT allowed to talk like that about me. You don’t know SHIT about me, Catra. Not a single piece of crap. You want to know why I own companies? My mother gave them to me. ON MY 18th birthday! SHE MADE ME C.E.O the day I graduated. And you know why? Because… because… because FUCK YOU!" Glimmer let her fist land on the floor, but an inch from Catras face. "You and I will never be friends. I will do my best to be happy for Adoras sake. But you… I hope you die of cancer." Then she spit in Catras face and climbed off her.

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As Catra lay on the floor, the words 'you messed up big time' were rolling on repeat in front of her eyes. Figuratively speaking, even if it did look like those messages on the commuter rail "Next stop Plumeria Avenue, mind the gap." What WAS in her field of vision was a very angry Glimmer.

And she has every right to be angry…

Catra’s youth hadn't actually been that painful, at least not physically, since she learned early on that the one who struck first or threw the first insult rarely got the second one. The problem was that she never grew out of it. Once she got real friends, she would have been able to let her guard down. Right? But she didn't. Heck, it wasn't until Adora walked into her life that she began to remotely hold back. Scorpia, poor thing, got her fishes warm from her when they first met and Lonnie… that COULD have been something. Catra swallowed. She wanted to scream "I'M SORRY" to Glimmer. Take it all back. Tell her that it wasn't her fault, that she knee-jerked and she KNEW she was an asshole.

But she couldn’t. She was still breathing to fast, her pulse was still at 110. She was just that inch to upset to calm down. A part of her wished Glimmer would throw that punch. To actually hit her. To give her a reason to remodel her stupid face.

The other part, the screaming one, tried its best to tell her how extremely stupid that would be. If she wanted just the iota of a chance to actually befriend Glimmer, she had to stop. Now.

In the end, all she managed was to keep quiet. And when Glimmer spit her in the face, she didn't even wipe it off.

She had to give it to Glimmer. She was fierce and tough when she had to. Finally she got up from the floor and sat down, as far away from Glimmer as she could. She shot Glimmer a glance once or twice. Was she crying? Yeah. And she was the one that made her cry. *Fuck* . The lump in Catra's stomach didn't exactly shrink at the sight. But the one time she tried to say something Glimmer hissed at her. So she sat where she sat. And then the motor turned on again with a roar, effectively ending every attempt at conversation. It was a relief, even if it came with hurt ears.

Then she threw a glance through the window to look at Scorpia, who had turned the music off for some reason (and the only reason she could tell was for the fact that the visualizer connected to the radio had gone black. She noticed how Scorpia’s hands turned the steering wheel with rapid movements.

And then she noticed two things that made her freeze. She instantly ran over to Glimmer, screaming at her. Glimmer screamed back. Great. Not only didn't she hear her, she wasn't going to listen either. She reached out for Glimmer's pocket and grabbed the cell. Glimmer rose and tried to take it back, While Catra wrote frantically and finally she pushed the cellphone in Glimmer's face.

It's not Scorpia driving.

Glimmer stared at the screen, then at Catra. Then she took the phone and wrote *u sure?*

Catra nodded and pointed at the window. It took a few seconds for Glimmer to notice but she managed to see what Catra had seen. The driver's left hand was a perfectly normal hand.

And once the driver turned their head so it became visible they knew. The driver wore a red skimask.

***

Glimmer’s first reaction was panic. Even with the small chance of the one in the drivers seat being someone else completely, another bad guy who just happened to wear a red ski mask, the situation still called for panic.

The second was frustration. This whole situation was completely ridiculous! They were chasing a robber, which was the police job to begin with, then they decided to pay a visit to a crazy brit, then they decided to let said brit drive them in a completely out of bounds vehicle, and THEN said vehicle was STOLEN!

Glimmer would have ripped Catra a new one, hadn’t she reminded herself that first of all, she wasn’t talking to Catra, and second, she had been the one insisting on doing at least two of the above

mentioned things and one that they really couldn’t prevent from happening. Catra was staring at the driver with a frenzy Glimmer hadn’t seen in her before. *It’s almost like she’s human.*

Catra grabbed Glimmer's phone and began to text, but Glimmer snatched it back and put it back in her pocket. She glared at Catra and crossed her arms. Catra on her side, stared at Glimmer. Then her eyes sank to the ground. She looked rather squashed for a moment when a frown grew on her face and she opened her mouth.

“TAKE OUT YOUR PHONE!” Screaming on the top of her lungs, Glimmer could actually hear her, but she had to be close.

“NO WAY! I’M NOT TALKING TO YOU!”

“SO WHAT ARE YOU DOING NOW THEN?”

“WELL, WE’RE DEFINITELY NOT TALKING!”

“ARE YOU REALLY GOING… GLIMMER, PICK UP YOUR PHONE!”

“I AM NOT TALKING TO YOU, I SAID!”

“CALL THE POLICE, YOU BLOCKHEAD!”

Glimmer had a reply somewhere along the line of 'Oh so NOW it's okay to call the cops' But she didn’t. It was hard enough to hear, but even if she was angry, not even she would argue against calling the police, if Catra now HAD changed her mind. She produced the phone from her pocket but she didn’t get a chance to do anything else with it because suddenly the driver turned their head and looked at them. Two cold dark eyes glared at them from beneath the mask. The idea had struck Glimmer the moment she saw the mask, but it seemed to fantastic. The next moment, the driver put their left hand in their pocket and produced a gun. A skimask was one thing. A tenchcoat another. But a red skimask, a green dirty trenchcoat, AND a gun? That was to many coincidences to be a coincidence. It HAD to be the robber, this ‘Perfuma’. Glimmer shot Catra a glance, she seemed to have the

same idea. The driver held the gun up for them to see for a few seconds, then they put it gently on the dashboard.. The message was clear. *Don't do anything and I won't use it.*

Catras eyes shot daggers. *Well done, Sparkles.*

Glimmers eyes shot back. *How the heck was I to know that she could hear us?* Catra rolled her eyes and signed for Glimmer to move to the rear part of the car. She put her mouth to her ear and said, in a loud, but not screaming voice,

"We need to get out of here."

"What a brilliant discovery, Einstein. "

"Hey! Save the attitude for when we are safe on the outside! I think I have an idea how to get us out of here, but I need you to trust me."

"No fucking way I am trusting YOU!"

Catra furrowed her brows. "Are you telling me you rather stay in an army vehicle with an armed madwoman instead of trusting me and get out of here?"

"Yes! Because I am never going to trust you, ever! With that madwoman I at least know where the gun is!"

Catra sighed, at least it looked like she was doing that.

"Alright, I get that I insulted you…"

"You didn't insult me. Insult is a way too simple word to describe what you did to me!"

"Well, like you didn't… LOOK HERE!" She swung her head around, but the driver didn't seem to notice her shouting. "Look here, she added slightly lower, "Can we just have a truce until we get out of here? You can leave me bleeding in a ditch if you want, just… just let us get out first, okay?"

“You get out. I stay.”

“Glimmer…”

“Wow. Using my first name. Impr…”

Catra took a step forward and grabbed Glimmer's jacket. Then she hissed in her ear. “Glimmer. I get it. I’m really really fucking sorry and I’m sorry I hurt your feelings but now is NOT the time to behave like a brat! Either you help me get us out of here or I can do it myself, but stop being like this okay? You want to get back home to arro...Bow?”

Glimmer couldn’t do anything but nod to that question. “Okay. You go up to the driver's seat and watch out until you see a redlight or something like that.”

“And you are going to do what?”

“There is an electric lock system that blocks the door lock, making it impossible to open the back door as long as the ignition is on. But it is possible to override it so the door can be opened. We just need to match it with a red light and hopefully she won’t notice.” Glimmer had no real objection to Catra’s plan, but she wasn’t completely ready to agree with her. There was one small doubt left in her mind.

“Are you even sure it’s this Perfuma?” Catra looked at a point far from Glimmer for a second before she bit back.

“Why do you ask that question NOW?”

“Well… if it's her, she didn’t seem to recognize you, that’s all.”

Catra pinched her nose. “Can we please leave playing Hercule Poirot until we are OUT of this vehicle?”

Glimmer shrugged her shoulders. She glared at Catra, but she placed herself next to the window anyway. The driver turned their head and shot her a cold clance. they tapped briefly on the gun.

Glimmer swallowed. She tried to see out of the front window, but it wasn't as easy as she expected. The snow had begun to fall again and she couldn't see very far. She squinted her eyes, but it was still hard to make out any contours in the falling snow, and the wind-shield wipers didn't help either.

"Are you going to tell me if there is a red light or are you still too damn pissed off to actually think, Sparkles?"

Catra's voice in her ear startled her and she swung around, almost knocking Catra out in the process.

"Don't scare me like that!"

"We're in a truck with an armed lunatic, and *I* scare you? Try to focus, okay?"

"I AM! There just hasn't been a…" In that moment, green lights became visible in the distance. Glimmer and Catra could see them turn yellow and they could sense the driver swear.

"Okay, we need to be quick. You take the door. I will jam this screwdriver into this fuse box."

"Are you NUTS?"

"Look, I helped Scorpia fix this a few years back. I know this will work, okay?"

Glimmer closed her eyes and took a long breath. "I meant, JAMMING a metal screw driver into a FUSE BOX? You wanna get electrocuted?"

"You wanna get out or not? Besides, you said you wanted me dead! Why do you care? Now get to the door. On my signal, release the hatch!"

Glimmer did as she was told. The engines' roar ceased and soon they were at a standstill. In that moment, Catra thrusted the screwdriver into the box. There wasn't a sound, not even a spark,

and without any drama, Glimmer could open the door. Now the door was wide open to the snow and the weak afternoon light that managed to break through the clouds occasionally. There was no car behind them, luckily enough, and Glimmer began to crawl out.

Unfortunately again, at that moment, the car began to move. With only one leg on the outside, and most of her on the inside, Glimmer lost her balance and almost fell out of the car. She had a scream prepared, when two hands grabbed her free arm.

“I got you, sparkles!”

And she did. Catra was surprisingly strong.

“What now?”

“We have to jump.”

“From a moving car? That’s lethal!”

“It has a maximum speed of 35 mph, Glimmer…”

“Still enough to get hurt.”

“Glimmer…”

She looked at Catra. Then at the driver who had yet to notice the open door.

"I still don’t trust you."

"You don't have to trust me, okay? You just have to jump with me."

"THAT'S LITERALLY THE DEFINITION OF TRUST!"

Glimmer had raised not only her voice but her arms to the air. For a second they just stood and looked at each other, panting. Glimmer heard Catra’s upset breathing and she felt her own heart beating with excitement. And then the realization hit.

She could hear Catra's breathing. That meant that the engine had stopped. More or less at the same time they turned their hands to look at the window. The driver had turned their head around and looked straight at them both, eyes darkened with anger. Glimmer swallowed. Slowly they turned their head back again, the engine roared to life and they continued to roll. Catra made a gesture to Glimmer, to *open the damn door!* Glimmer obeyed, perhaps a bit to quick, cause the door swung up with quite some force and hit the side of the car. There wasn't an audible sound but they did feel the hit. And the same was with the driver, who without slowing down, they grabbed the gun and slowly aimed. First at Catra. Then at Glimmer. Then at Catra again. Finally it seemed like they decided that Glimmer was the most annoying and aimed.

BOOM!

"Is she…"

"Probably."

"Does she know…"

"Probably not…"

The next second a shot rang out and the glass went from see-through to a grey cracked mass. The rang through their ears still and Catra could only imagine how it would have been for the Perfuma. And as on a cue, the car began to wobble across the road. Catra swallowed, and she sensed Glimmer doing the same.

“On three?” She took a slow step closer to Glimmer.

“On three. One…”

“THREE!”

Catra grabbed Glimmer's arm and pulled her out of the car. They rolled along the wet and cold road a few times and it hurt like shit. But they were out. And alive. The driver seemed to regain some control over the car as it straightened up its route as they lay there on the cold and snowy street, watching the car slowly disappear in the distance.

“Glimmer?”

“Ummmm?”

“You’re alive?”

“Think so…”

“M’kay.”

As they lay still on the cold street, all she could think of now was Adora. It helped a bit, at least she felt warmer. Okay, better get moving. Loud she said,

"Could you bother to get off me, it's…"

"Are you saying I am heavy?" Catra sighed. *Yep.*

"I am saying that it's a cold street and my body hurts in a few places."

"Same shit, different words." But she got up anyway. Her legs seemed a bit unsteady, but… overall she was okay. Catra decided to test the waters.

"So...um… You okay?"

"You don't care so skip asking." Catra felt how the cold got even more noticable after Glimmers words.

"I care…"

"Hah! No. But I bet it feels nice to play pretend. DON'T!" sha added, when Catra opened her mouth again. "Once this shit is over we won't have to talk to each other again."

So I was right then. Yep. Thanks a lot world. This robber better be Perfuma or this whole day has been a damn waste of time… Catra knew she had a tendency to imagine the worst. She had learned from an early age not to rely on her own experience, due to more than a few misunderstandings (was THAT what you meant being the least damaging one) and therefore she had no illusions. So, maybe she had saved Glimmer from being abducted by a crazy terrorist. It would not change her opinion about her, not considering their history, and especially not considering how this day had developed. She had been sincere with her apology, but all things considered, Glimmer was not buying it.

And she wouldn't have herself, had she been in this position.

***

Glimmer felt that this had been probably the worst day to just wear pantyhoses and she made a silent pact with herself to never leave home without jeans in the winter. she was feeling how her legs got wetter and colder by the second.

Now let’s call the c… Oh shit.”

Glimmer grinded her teeth, as Catra was silent.

“Are you going to ask me what it is?”

“...What’s the matter?”

“I left my phone in the car.”

“Oh shit.”

“Yeah. Well done, you could at least have given it back to me!”

“So this is MY fault?”

“Yeah! You took it from my pockets to text!”

“I did not! I told you to use it to call the police! I have no idea what you did with it afterwards!”

"Yeah, why was it so important to call the police all of a sudden, miss 'don’t want to get involved?"

Catra glared at Glimmer. Glimmer glared at Catra. Then she sighed. “Whatever. We just need to find a phone…"

"Yeah. Now where the heck are we?”

“Halfway between Brightmoon and Salty Springs.”

“Dang. We did ride in that thing for some time.”

“Yeah.”

“Any idea where the closest petrol station is?”

“Nope. Not without my phone.”

“Yeah, where is YOUR phone anyway?”

“Also in the car. With my jacket.”

It was at that moment Glimmer realized that Catra was only wearing a scarf and a shirt. She looked extremely uncomfortable.

She saved me. She got us both out of the car. She could have left me. But she helped me. -yeah, pulling me out of a MOVING car! Helpful indeed…

But If I hadn't been so loud we could have just walked out… And she made sure that I was to fall on her...

As they stood there on the cold street, one half-wet, the other fully cold, minds began to cool down and things began to appear slightly less lethal. Save for the risk of freezing to death but that was something that had to wait for later. It's easier to panic when dry and warm. Part of this could be tributed to the fact that Catra right now very much lived up to her nickname. Something more catty Glimmer had hardly seen. Her hair was wet and scruffed, and she had scrunched up her nose in a very ‘I am not satisfied with this food’-way. Adding that sight to her previous inner monologue, it was getting harder and harder for Glimmer to stay upset. She still didn’t *like* Catra. But she stopped being angry and began to feel… well, something akin to feeling sorry for her. Glimmer felt her emotions hitting her hard *again* just like before when she had let her fury reing free over catra. But with a slight

difference… So when Catra said, “So, Sparkles… anything to say?” She looked down at her shoes (very nice high heel boots btw, only 275$!) and said, “My dad is Korean.”

Catra looked at her with an unsure look. “ookay? Figures, you said before you were h...” But Glimmer interrupted.

“I know I look… Okay, I shouldn’t say this but… Growing up, a lot of kids told me that I looked weird.”

“Okay…”

“But it was okay!” she added quickly. “Mostly.” Beat. “Mom and Dad loved me and we were happy. Okay, so we were like stinking rich and maaaybe I was a bit spoiled. I never got a pony though!”

“Sparkles, I didn’t think you…”

“And then… Dad went missing. On a business trip in Italy. He was missing for over a year. And then he was declared dead.”

“Um...bummer.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes at Catra. “You’re a real empath. I was… five when he disappeared. I was not taking it well, but that’s pretty much what can be expected. Don’t worry, I have a good therapist. I feel much better now.”

“Um, yeah. Glimmer, I…”

“Mom on the other side… She didn’t really take it well.”

Catra looked from side to side, still unsure how to react. In the end she began to speak. “Yeah, figures. If something happened to Ador…” But Glimmer wasn’t done. “Now, perhaps a normal mom would have gone all in, full-metal mom, you know? MY mother… Decided to go all in as the leader of the company. Chairman of all the boards. Drown herself in work, I suppose.”

“Mhmm.”

“Now, up until now… I hadn’t really been exposed to other kids that much. I mean… Between mom, dad and the staff… I had a pretty neat life. Now, I had to go to school. Sure, it was a private school. But that only means the kids wear a uniform. It does *not* mean they behave better.”

Say something say something say something...“Shit.” Catra bit her lip, but Glimmer didn't seem to bother.

“Yeah. You can imagine. I have been getting my fair share of slurs. And at least ⅓ of them was from kids that knew exactly what they meant and why. I was… lonely. Most people that hang out with me did it because I had money. or their parents felt that it looked good to be on mom's good side. ‘Our children are SUCH good friends…’ That phrase made me sick back in the day.”

“Yeah, I figure. listen, Glimmer…”

“And how did MOM tackle this? She gave me stuff. Bought me everything I pointed at and a few things I didn’t point at just to shut me and her bad conscience up.”

“Poor you who had her own pool. But Glimmer…”

“One? Hah. Five. More or less a full waterpark. With slides. And…”

“GLIMMER!”

“Yeah?”

“Look. I get it. Things have been hard for you as well. You hate to get your privilege thrown in your face. I get it. And I AM a fucking bitch. I suck at emotions and I let my bad temper get the better of me all the time. I shouldn’t have lashed out on you… that much. I hit a weak spot and for that I am really fucking sorry and you will get a formal apology once we’re out of here, but I didn’t mean that you should tell the story of your life. What I meant was ‘What do you think we should do know?”

“Oh…” Glimmer got beet-red in her face. But the next moment Catra was next to her, putting her arms around her.

“What are you doing?”

“I figured you could use a hug.”

"You said you suck at emotions?"

"Emotions are hard. Hugs are simple."

“Thanks.” They stood still, arms around each other on the cold street for quite some time before Glimmer said, “You fucking jerk.”

“You’re welcome, capitalist swine.”

“Your insults are getting uninspired.”

“It’s been a long day. Call me tomorrow and I will call you a sad excuse for a baboon's hat that tries to imitate a human.”

“...”

“I said you should call me tomorrow. Now let’s move. Anything is better than standing.here.”

Glimmer nodded. Arms around each other to steer away the cold, they began to walk down the road in the direction the car had gone. It had been a few minutes since the roar had died down in the distance, but it shouldn’t be too far off, if they could find a cab or perhaps a police car. Glimmer suddenly felt like she was going to fast. She HAD wished for Catra's death earlier. And here they walked side by side… Would Catra really believe her?

“This is just a truce, right?”

Catra glanced at her and rolled her eyes. “I dunno, sparkles. What’s a ‘truce’ for you…?”

Glimmer groaned. “That’s not even a joke!”

Catra smirked. “I got a groan. That means there’s a punchline somewhere.”

“Adora didn’t take you for your sense of humour I hear.”

“Nope, she loves my ass. She even… ADORES IT!”

“AAAARGH! Did I really hit you earlier?”

“Nah, it’s probably an after effect of the chock.”

“You were misbehaving earlier too!”

“Oh, paid attention, did we? I think you like me after all, Sparkles.”

“Go eat dog poo, scum.”

Slowly and surely they made their way down the road. The time was not more than 1.39 p.m. but it felt like evening. At least the snow had ceased to fall, and they stayed close to keep the temperature up. The passed a three where someone had put up a sign, advertising a christmas farmers market. 'Fresh Christmas trees,' it said. 'Ecologically raised Turkeys. Sustainable Eggnog. Low carbon print mistletoe'

They both glared at the a bit to cheerful, a bit to hipstery sign.

"Wanna visit that market, drink some eggnog, kick some ass?" Catra smirked. "You can have the eggnog for yourself."

Glimmer laughed. "And what the hay is 'low carbon print mistletoe?'"

"Probably made from recycled ivies." They both started to laugh. Suddenly there were steps behind them. Someone was running towards them. They both froze on the spot.

"Did… the spirit of Christmas farmers hear us and want revenge?"

Catra gave her a sideways glance. "What the heck, Glimmer?"

"Don't tell me you're not sc...surprised!?"

"No, but… 'did the robber wait in hide for us to catch us' would maybe be a more relevant exclamation?"

"Well excuse ME for not being rational when tracking a robber on a cold snowy street and suddenly there's steps behind you!"

"Jesus christ Glimmer...

But whatever Catra-bickering that was on it's way was halted as they heard a familiar voice.

“Lasses! Lasses! Wait! Wait for me!”

They both turned to find Scorpia running towards them. Glimmer gave a sigh of relief but Catra gritted her teeth. “Embrace yourself, sparkles.”

“WhatUMMMPF!”

Soon, they were wrapped in a oneway, threesome hug.

“I can’t believe I found you! I have been looking all over for you!”

Glimmer blinked. “You mean you have been… RUNNING?”

Scorpia nodded. “Uhu.”

“The whole time since the car was stolen?”

Scorpia shrugged her shoulders. “What else should I have done?”

“I dunno, get a cab? Call the police?”

“Nah. I don’t trust the bottle and stoppers.”

"Bottle and what now?!" Glimmer gave Scorpia a questioning look. Catra came to the rescue.

“Coppers, Glimmer. Scorpia is an classic punk cockney.”

“Ooookay… but you didn’t answer my question, why running?”

“Gave me a bigger area to cover! And here you guys are! And you are all safe!”

Glimmer frowned. “I wouldn’t call it safe. We don’t know where the car is and inside it is my phone and Catras jacket AND phone.”

“Oh! I thought something was off when you were outside with so little clothing! Well, no worries! You can have my jacket, luv!"

Before neither Glimmer nor Catra could protest she had taken her jacket off, pushed Catra and Glimmer together and thrown it over their shoulder.

"There! Warm and cosy!"

"Scorp! Come on! It's not…"

"Yes it is, and don't protest. None of my friends gets to freeze to death on my watch."

Scorpias smile covered both Glimmer and catra. Catra huffed but Glimmer had a hunch that her heart wasn't in it. Glimmer smiled back at Scorpia.

Had this been a cartoon we would have been instant friends, she thought to herself. *Well, I wouldn’t mind. She's way easier to like than Catra.*

They walked in relative silence for a while, Catra and Glimmer said nothing. Scorpia on her hand let out the occasional comment on a variety of subjects. Her favorite Christmas treat was gingerbread

with a slice of blue cheese, her favorite Christmas movie was "Emmet the otter's Jugband Christmas" and she immediately began to sing a sentimental but pretty beautiful song that Glimmer assumed were from the movie in question. She sang the whole song, as they walked through the empty street. Glimmers legs was starting to protest against the walking, but in a strange way it was pretty cosy. It was a nice winters day. Scorpia had a very nice voice and the song grew on Glimmer. Okay, the fact that some nutjob had stolen Scorpias car, Catras jacket and her phone was… It wasn't a *good* thing but right now it felt like things was going to be okay. Even Catra was silent and seemed to be cool with everything.

Catra…

Glimmer suddenly became aware of the fact that Catra was staying really close to her and… dammit, didn't the woman actually make an effort to keep even steps with Glimmer, so the jacket would stay on. They didn't even have to hold on to it with their hands.

Glimmer shot her a sideways eye. *She's actually making an effort. Actually a pretty big effort.*

Glimmer remembered one time she had asked Adora (there had been a few beers involved but more than that it was a rare occasion where Catra hadn't been there.) what she felt was Catras best trait. She had originally planned to ask if Catra had any good traits at all but at the last minute she decided that that probably was giving away too much.

Adora had been silent for a few minutes, causing Glimmer to comment "Stop picturing her naked and answer me" to which Adora blushed and threw a napkin at Glimmer. Then she was silent for a few more minutes before she slowly said: "she's… It's hard to win her trust. It takes time. And if you get on her bad side she may never forgive you. But…"

"I did say *best* trait, Adora."

"I'm getting there!!! BUT, as I was going to say, if you manage to become her friend she's loyal until…. Death, I think. She will curse and insult you, but she will always look out for you. No matter what."

Back then Glimmer had grunted and grabbed another beer. But now, as she walked next to her, noticing how she handled the jacket and how patiently she listened to Scorpia…

She also thought about herself. What she had been prepared to do for Adora. For Bow.

What she unconsciously had planned to do for Scorpia.

And how much she despised Catra.

Well, had despised. Now she wasn't sure anymore.

Almost as hard as getting on your good side. Or something like that.

She took a deep breath.

It's hard to win her trust. It takes time.

"Adora… You're such an idiot…" She mumbled.

"Said something, Sparkles?"

"What!? N-no nothing. Nothing special."

"You said something about an idiot."

"Did I? Eh… I was… talking about the one who stole the car. What an idiot.!" She smiled at Catra who made a face and lifted an eyebrow back at her. "Who might be… your...friend… yes… um…"

Glimmer hoped her foot was good tasting. And then, once again the tension was broken by Scorpia who exclaimed:

"Hey! That's my car!"

And it was. It had derailed from the road and stood now… Parked was a strong word, but leaning against a crashed citybus, who in turn had managed to get derailed even more and had crashed against a huge oak tree. The only tree in at least 400 meter radius. At least seven smaller trees had been torn down on the way, but the old oak apparently remembered the days of the uprising against the Englishmen and stood its ground. *That's one way to get the drivers attention…* Glimmer thought to herself.

"Crawley! What did they do to you!" Scorpia ran to her car, but stopped abruptly. A slim tall figure climbed out of the driver's seat, holding a gun and wearing the red ski mask. They instantly recognized the robber. Or, Glimmer did. Catra too, obviously. The robber pointed the gun at Scorpia, then Catra and finally Glimmer.

"Don't move. Don't any of you move and no one will be hurt!"

They all stood still, but not moving didn't mean not talking.

"Babe, don't do this! We can clear this up!"

The robber frowned. "Don't think you can sweet talk your way out of this, lady! I have seen a bit too much of you lot today. I'm getting pretty pissed off!"

"Look!" Catra interrupted. "We understand that you want to keep your face hidden, but we know it's you and…"

"You SAW me?" The angry look in the robbers eyes got mixed up with something akin to fear. "You saw my face? When?"

“Right before you robbed the liquor store! Okay, I mostly saw your back but it was pretty obvious it was y…”

“Over here! Backs against the car!” They all obeyed, and Catra began to realize what a horrible mistake she had made. As they stood there against the cold carcass, Scorpia leaned over and whispered, “I don’t think this is Perfuma, Cat!”

Catra rolled her eyes, albeit with a touch of fear. "Yeah… I’m beginning to see that.”

“SHUT UP!” The robber waived the gun, and began to mutter to herself. “..cn’t leave witnes… but I can't do this either…fuck fuck fuck…”

No one said anything. Running wasn’t an option, they could hide behind the crawler perhaps, but what good would that do other than buying them some extra seconds… The robber finally made up her mind and looked at them. "Ok, this has to end now. You're..."

"Drop the gun!"

They all (robber included) looked at where the sound had come from.

Suddenly there was another slim tall figure standing there, holding a gun and pointing it at them. This one wore a pink skimask with crocheted flowers sewn on it. The contract to the grey trenchcoat and gun was massive.

"Drop the gun I said! And no one will get hurt!"

The robber instantly raised her gun and pointed at the pink newcomer.
"I was here first! You drop the gun!"

"No, YOU drop the gun"

"That's not… I will shoot! I will shoot if you don't drop the gun!"

"I will shoot you too if you don't drop the gun!"

Scorpia had been standing there scratching her hair the whole exchange. Now she spoke up.

"Um, guys… can't you both drop the gun?"

"NO!/No!"

"Okay…."

For a while, No one moved. (And therefore No one was hurt.) Glimmer began to plan how she could disarm both the baddies and be the hero of the day and let Catra be the one begging for her to be her friend. (Technically they had made up. But Glimmer still felt annoyed that she had spilled her life story. Catra wasn't all bad but… Not all bad didn't mean 'not jerk!' *But she is… no! I don't care what Adora thinks about us! I am* not *going to let Catra think befriending me is that* that *easy. If she has to* earn *it, she will treasure it so much more! Yes! Walking arm in arm be damned.)* She tried to take the whole situation in. Catra to her right, still in the jacket. Scorpia in front of them, standing right in the robber… *But who is this pink one? Is that also a robber? Red hood… No, that's copyrighted… WORK BRAIN! REd hood works.* Scorpia is standing in red hoods line of fire. Pink hood a bit desperate down between the trees to our right and red hoods left. Okay. She had it now.

First I take out number one with a quick kick. ...but then the other will have free range at my back. Okay, first I push Scorpia at number 2, who will have to drop the gun to catch her. THEN I kick the gun from the hand of number 1. ...but maybe she's so fast she manages to shoot...who's she aiming at? Me or Catra? She looks nervous. Perhaps If I push Scorpia at number 2 and Catra at number 1… and then I take the guns and point them at them both? That would be SO COOL! ...But I'm not a good shot. On the other hand, they don't know that!!

But Catra might tell them. Okay, she doesn't know either, but she's nasty enough to do it anyway. That is such irresponsible behavior! Okay, so I can't push her then… But if I Push Catra at SCORPIA…

She never got the chance to put her plan in motion. In the same moment Catra threw the jacket aside, pushed Scorpia towards number 2 (if Catra now used the same indexing system) and threw herself at number one. Aiming or not, number one wasn't prepared to shoot, but she was much sturdier than Glimmer had anticipated. Instead of falling over, she knocked Catra in the head with the gun, then she shot a warning shot at the ground.

"Okay you idiots, I am SERIOUS. NO ONE MOVES!" She rapidly pointed the gun from person to person. She began to back off until she stood some 20 meters away from them, then she began to run.

Instantly, Scorpia released herself from number 2s arms, ran forward with a "WILDCAT!" and began to check her.

"Nooooo! She's deaaad!!!"

Now Glimmer reacted. She also ran up to Catra, but in contrast to Scorpia, she knew where to check for a pulse. And there it was. Her heart was still beating, although a bit slow.

"She’s alive. She's just unconscious. "

"Really?"

"Yes, really."

Scorpia sighed with relief. "Phew… I was so scared. Well then." She rose and shouted "GET BACK HERE YOU NITWIT!" And began to follow red hood.

Left at the Crawler was Glimmer and number 2, who rose from the ground where she had fallen under Scorpia.

"How is she?" The geniun care in number 2's voice supriced Glimmer, and she was not willing to buy it.

"Like I am going to tell you that!"

Number 2 raised their eyebrows in suprice.

"What? I haven't done anything!"

"You are wearing a pink ski mask and you pointed a gun at me!"

"I wasn't pointing at you!

"It looked like that! How do I know the two of you aren't in cahoots?"

"Why would we?"

"Ski masks? Guns? Erratic behaviour?"

Number 2 frowned under the skimask, at least it seemd like that. "There is NOTHING erratic with my behaviour! I am. In. Control! I am. At peace. With myself. "

It sounded like she said this as much to herself as to Glimmer, and she didn't buy it any more than them caring about Catra. "It sure didn't look like that!"

"Well, maybe if SOMEONE hadn't run off… or if Catra would have been conscious, she could have told you that I am very much in control, thank you!"

Glimmer furrowed her brows. "Do YOU know Catra?"

The other smiled under the skimask. "Of course I do! Didn't she… Oh… sorry, he he. " she giggled as she took off the mask, revealing a lean freckled face, which was surprisingly friendly. She also removed a hair pin, letting the longest and blondest hair Glimmer had seen loose. "Pleased to meet you. I'm Perfuma. I go

with She/they-pronouns but you can pick whichever you're most comfortable with."

I'll say she is!

Glimmer stared, for possibly the 27th time today. “YOU’RE Perfuma?”

Perfuma looked back at her with the friendliest eyes she had seen, and a warm smile. “Of course. Why wouldn’t I be?”

“You’re wearing a ski mask. ...Were wearing a ski mask...”

“It is cold today. Are you implying that my name isn’t Perfuma because I am wearing a balaclava?” There was no anger in the voice, just a genuine wonder. And that, somehow, made Glimmer even more unsure how to react.

“N-no, it’s just that…”

"And who, may I ask, are you?"

"Um… I am Glimmer Moon… and… well… she/her? "

Perfuma scrutinized Glimmer for some time, like she tried to remember where she had met Glimmer. Then her face lit up and she raised a finger and smiled.

"OH! I remember you! You're the capitalist slag that bought old McKenzies farm, tore it down and built a carbondioxidespewing plant there which not only destroys the planet but is also butt-ugly?"

Glimmer blinked. "Um… Yes… S-sorry?"

Perfuma laughed. "Eh. Old news. After trying to burn it down we realized that you had actually bothered to sanitize the grounds around it from the waste so it all equals out in the end. But please don’t do it again!"

If dad would have been taken over by mom's spirit, this is probably how he would appear…also, that explains a few incidents

last month... Glimmer thought to herself. She looked at her shoes for the 15th time today. Perfuma gave her a warm smile.

“You seem a bit confused, Glimmer. Come. Take my hand.” She did so. “Now, close your eyes. And breathe. In. Out. In. Out. Now, imagine a light and comfortable place.”

Glimmer found it hard not to oblige. Perfumas hands were as slim as her general figure, but they were also surprisingly warm and soft.

She closed her eyes. The place -and moment- she imagined was back in Bows house a few months back, when they and Adora had pie after their ...interesting… Reunion. She had been happy and content that day.

"Doesn't it feel better now?"

"...actually, yes."

"You do feel a bit tense. Not to much, but a bit. Have you considered meditation on a regular basis? The world is much easier to handle if the mind is at peace, in my experience."

Glimmer wasn’t sure if she did trust Perfuma or if it was because she was dealing with a possibly crazy women with a gun. Nevertheless she felt like she had no real choice but to adjust to this level of chaos. And mayne that was okay.

Maybe add a few dollars to that check to Scorpia in case they have problems buying meds.

I may have to ask Catra.

CATRA.

"Catra!" Glimmer let go of Perfuma's hands and ran over to Catra. Now she did what she should have done from the start. She lay down Scorpia's jacket on the ground and moved Catra so she lay on the jacket. Luckily her clothes wasn't to wet, but she was cold. Glimmer wrapped the jacket around Catra.

What to do now? She thought to herself. *Wait for sScorpia is probably the best but.* She looked at the Crawler. Then the thought struck her. The car. Her phone. Catras jacket. With a cuss (which caused Perfuma to frown) she rose from Catras' side and ran over to the Car. She didn't have to rummage through the seating area for too long, the phone lay on the floor, the jacket next to it. She grabbed both items and turned around, only to find Perfuma sitting next to the unconscious Catra, singing some kind of Mantra, while clapping her hands. Something was laying on the ground, a small stream of smoke rose from it. Glimmer stood a few feet away, pending development.

Finally she asked "What, um… are you doing?"

Perfuma looked up. She stopped chanting, but she continued clapping. "I am helping her spirit to stay inside her body."

"...I did say she wasn’t dead, right?"

Again, that patient smile. "Oh Yes. But you see, when unconscious, the spirits have a tendency to drift away, and it may take some time before they're all collected. This ceremony will help her be herself again the moment she wakes up. This chanting is an old shamanistic ritual I learned from a peruan mystic who worked at the same factory as me once."

Glimmer blinked.

"And the clapping is helping the soul to focus on this location. It’s so easy to forget where you are when you get knocked out."

Glimmer felt how her left eye twitched.

"And the frankincense? You always carry that around?"

"The what? Oh that! That’s weed."

"Oookay. And that's for…?"

"Me. It makes the side effects of my meds more tolerable. And it helps me deal with unforseen stress."

Glimmer had so many questions. What meds? What factory? Did Perfuma get knocked out often? But again, destiny was not to provide her with answers, because in that moment, Catra shot up from the ground like a stepped-on rake.

"I NEED TO HELP SCORPIA!"

And off she ran.

Both Glimmer and perfuma yelled after her, all for nothing. She was long gone.

***

"Where is she where is she where the FUCK is she.. "

At first it had been easy, the snow showed fresh traces of two people running. One in sneakers, the other in size 14 boots. *Only good thing that came out of those two year working that stinking shoe sellers…* But then the footsteps had gone into a small forest, which made it harder to move forward through all the twigs and bushes. And then she had ended up on a small path, which was annoyingly well trampled.

Who in their right mind chooses to take a walk through HERE? NOW?

Catra had sharp eyes though, and after a few moments she managed to make out the traces of Scorpias boots on the still

snow covered edge, so she began to follow the path towards left. *South, or whatever it is if you want to be fancy* . Catra was very rarely introspective, a combination of habit and disinterest the irony of, amongst other things, spending part of the morning trash talking Scorpia and now running as if her life depended on it to help her was completely wasted on her. Her whole being was focused on finding Scorpia. Somewhere behind her she could hear faintly Glimmer shouting something about "Wait!" She sneered to herself, not stopping for a second.

Wait. No way was she going to wait. Scorpia was big and could take anyone in a fight, but she wasn't more bulletproof than anyone else, and considering they were facing someone stupid enough to fire a gun straight into bulletproof glass…

Why did I think that was Perfuma? She would never…

Okay, I can't really rule that *out. But she would* never *fire a gun at Scorpia. Not even raise a gun.* This *dude is crazy on a whooole different level.* Briefly she felt a cold shiver down her intestiens as another thought struck her.

Or worse than that. She's completely sane.

She shoved the thoughts aside, as she reached a small cross road in the forest, and she had to stop. Which way? She knew Scorpia, she always chose left, but that also came with not following a robber or whatever it was. Whoever it was. Okay, so it hadn't been Perfuma, but no one could blame Catra for believing that! So, which way to go…

"Which way…*pant* … did they go?"

"GAH!" Glimmer was suddenly next to her, panting like crazy.

"...Did I...Scare...you?" Catra gave Glimmer a brief stare. Then her attention focused on Glimmers high heeled boots. Had she actually ran through the snow on those? Damn. She had spark. Catra decided to be impressed by her. Later. Loud she said:

“Hmpf. No, you just startled me, sparkles. I don’t know... “

“You...don’t...know if I...scared you… or...you don’t know… where they...went?”

“The latter, sparkles…”

“Okay...Just needed the...clarification.”

Then Glimmer turned silent, probably concentrating on catching her breath. Catra did her best to live up to her nickname, trying to sniff for some scent or anything that could tell them the ruote. Suddenly she felt a scent! Was it… She sniffed again. Oh yes! It was a faint smell of cookies, chocolate cookies. She began to run instantly with Glimmer on her heels, still shouting “”Wait!” and “Why are you going this way?”

But she didn’t stop. No way. Not until she had found something. She finally found that something as the path ended in a very small glade, where an equally small, old abandoned barn stood. It might have been a shed judging by the look, but then it would have been a very large shed. But on the other hand... She shook her head, *stay out of my mind, Adora! Your beautiful face doesn’t help now!* The door was open, but there was not a movement, not a sound. She looked at the ground. There was a trace of shoes up to the barn door. Sneakers. Okay, so the non-perfuma baddie was in the barn. But where was Scorpia? There had been no tracks or signs or anything showing where she could be. Catra froze. Maybe it was too late! Maybe Scorpia lay bleeding somewhere in the forest, far away from any kind of help. Far away from Perfuma, far away from… her.

She shook her head again. *Try to be rational here, Catherine! There has been no sound of a gun or anything.*

She could have been beaten to death.

….Scorpia? Really?

...Okay, maybe not. Overreacting.

Again Steps behind her, again accompanied with heavy panting. Glimmer.

“Is STOP an... un...known word to you?”

“Have your friends been in mortal danger before?”

“Yes.” Catra raised both eyebrows, to which Glimmer responed with a deadpan glare and a heavy breath.

“...Sorry, stupid question.”

“Yeah, it was. Where are they?”

Catra pointed at the traces in the snow. “Baddie is in the barn. Shed. Whatever.”

“Barn.”

“Thanks. Scorpia, I don’t know.”

“GUYS! OVER HERE!” Scorpia whispered loudly to them as she peeked out from behind the corner of the barn. They ran over. “She’s inside! I chased her this far, but I didn’t want to go inside!”

They nodded.

“I mean, this thing looks ancient! I can probably fall apart anytime! It would be dangerous to go inside! I tried to warn her but…”

They looked at each other and simultaneously facepalmed.

"Why did you think that was a good thing to say?"

"Well, the shed looks like it will fall apart! Going inside is dangerous!"

"Yeah but… Nevermind."

Glimmer took out her phone. "Alright, I'm calling the police right now." But Scorpia put her hand over the phone.

"No."

"What? Scorpia, that woman is dangerous!"

"You don't know that!"

"Yes I do! She stole your car, robbed a liquor store and held us at gunpoint!"

"So? Anyone could do that!"

Catra and Glimmer shared a glance, Catra raising her brow and Glimmer nodding.

Not worth it.

"Okay, just CALM. THE FUCK. DOWN."

"we ARE calm! Wait, who said that?" Catra saw Glimmer turn her head, in angry confusion. She froze 3/4 throught the turn, as did Catra as she looked where Glimmer had looked. The person with the red balaclava, still wearing it by the way, was again there, standing in the doorway, pointing the gun at them.

"Stop. Talking. Especially the brit. And get in the barn."

"Shed."

Under the balaclava they could see the eyes slim and the person squeezed the trigger harder. Glimmer smiled awkwardly and walked into the shed. Catra and Scorpia followed.Catra tried to read the room. *Not that big a room. And they have less movement, with all the pillars and boxes or whatever to call them. I'm fast. They're getting desperate and maybe sloppy. I can take*

them a second time. I will take them this time. I mean…they're not that big.

As on cue, the robber took a few more steps back, placing themselves effectively out of Catras reach.

Okay. Smart. Definitely not *Perfuma, she would have… done something else.*

Once they all were inside, the robber kept their aim and began to talk.

"Alright. No funny business and NO. TALKING. Faces against the wall. I still don't like killing so don't force me to do it. Just let me leave. Nice and slow. No calling the cops. And you will live a few more years."

They all turned, facing the wall. Catra cursed silently. Okay, they were safe but… No one did this to her friends and got away with it. She had a particularly nasty comment regarding the robber on her lips but only the almost angelic image of Adora in her mind stopped her. *Don't be the hero..leave it to the professionals. Don't risk your life when there's little or nothing to gain. And above all… I want you to come back home. Always.*

Stupid Adora. Stupid lawyer mind. ...Alright, maybe caring for her wasn't a bad idea but…

Aaaargh! It's easier to be angry than in love! Glimmer would understand this! She…

From a dark corner of the room ran two squirrels. They knocked down a half-rotten wooden box, ran between Scorpias legs, climbed up a pillar and jumped out of a broken window. The robber reacted like the snap of a whip. She fired a shot. Everyone ducked, and it took a full minute before they all (again, robber included) realized that the only one hit was another one of the old barrels. This one had apparently been filled with gasoline, and at least some of it remained. The unmistakable smell could be sensed in the barn and a faint dripping sound was heard. The

robber, who began to look embarrassed under the hood, signed for them with the gun to stand up. Catra couldn't help to smirk.

"Stop. Laughing."

"I wasn't…"

"Oh sure. And losing an arm won't kill you!"

Catra bit her lip and looked away. She blushed with anger. She was supposed to be tougher than this! She was tougher than this!

But tough skin doesn't stop bullets.

Shut up, adora.

"Alright! No one moves!"

"Eh… Weren't we supposed to face the wall?" Scorpia had slowly raised her hand while she spoke.

"Yes you were! Why aren't you facing the wall?"

"Well, to be fair… we were facing the wall just now and you still fired." Scorpia still had her hand raised.

"I think she wanted to fire at the Squirrels, Scorpia." Catra couldn't hold back the comment. *Why* am *I like this...* The smell of gasoline grew stronger, the barrels seemed to contain quite a lot. *And who keeps that much gasoline in an old barn like this? Damn... It's actually a puddle now.*

"Take a step back, Sparkles, unless you want your shoes damaged."

"What? Is there something on the floor?

"Huh. Nice catch, wildcat! I was actually wondering about that and...

"SHUT UP! ALL OF YOU! TURN AROUND! NOW! IF ANYONE OF YOU MOVE *AFTER* YOU'VE TURNED AROUND YOU WILL BE TREATED LIKE THOSE SQURRELS!"

"WHAT DID YOU DO TO THOSE INNOCENT SQIRRELS!?"

Catra peeped over her shoulder, to find Perfuma standing in the doorway, eyes flashing with anger and her arms angrily at her side. She saw the robber turning around in surprise, however brief. Apparently the robber had adjusted to the chaos, because soon the gun was raised again, this time at Perfuma. The last time that occurred, she also had a gun. Not this time, which became fairly obvious as Perfuma slowly raised her arms in the air.

"I mean… they probably had it coming...Squirrels can be so rude...he he."

Catra's brain began to take in the situation. The robber had all of her focus on Perfuma. She could do it. Here was her second chance!

Here's our *second chance!* She turned her head, and found Glimmer's eyes. She nodded her head towards the robber. *Ready?*

Glimmer nodded. Catra held up her fingers. *On three?* Glimmer nodded. Catra raised one finger, then Glimmer moved. It annoyed the shit out of Catra and Glimmer probably felt really satisfied with that, in addition to the adrenaline rush. *Okay... she kinda earned that.*

She ran across the barn floor to the robber, proceeded with pulling down the Balaclava even further over the robbers head, making them temporarily blind. The Robber began to wake her arms around, still holding the gun. Catra was there in an instant, grabbing the gun arm, Scorpia holding the other in a tight grip. However, the robber was tough, and she kept wriggling and struggling. While the barn floor wasn't snow-covered, it still was wet from all the boots and shoes making it somewhat slippery. First the robber caused scorpia to slip. Scorpia managed to drag

the robber with her in the fall, causing her to land on the brits chest. However, it was the robber that exclaimed "OUCH!"

Damn… She IS a brick house!

The robber had managed to get out of Catras grip, but instead she managed to hit Glimmers calves, causing her to go "OUCHIT!" and fall straight on the robber. Sandwiched between the two, the robber exclaimed a "HUUUUUUHHHGRH" as all air was pushed out of her, and she finally dropped the gun. Catra quickly took it. She was prepared to shoot, but the robber rolled unconsciously to the floor once Glimmer rolled off.

"Damn…"

"You said it Sparkles."

"Blimey!"

"Yeah, you said it too, Scorpia."

"Is my jacket still whole?" Catra rolled her eyes.

"Is THAT your first question after surviving a hostage situation, Sparkles?"

"What, did you become deaf after… Okay, okay… Are you okay, Catra?"

"Think so. I have the gun."

"Good. Scorpia?"

"I'm fine."

"Good. Okay, here's my plan. Let's go back to your place." She pointed at Scorpia, who nodded at first but then she looked up and along with Catra, simultaneously raising an eyebrow.

"What about calling the cops, Glitter?" Catra was starting to feel tired and the line came out more exhausted and less bite-y as she

had planned.

"I don't know, Cat-turd, what about it? If I remember correctly, you wanted it as well just now." Catra looked away, as she felt Glimmer smirk and Scorpia and Perfuma frown at her.

"I… You… I panicked, okay? Nevermind what I said, you were the original goody two-shoes! Why have you changed your mind?

“Because of two reasons. 1. After all this crap I want to see who’s under the ski mask. If I will get nothing else out of this, I want my Scooby Doo-moment! 2. Before we decide what to do, let’s honor our host and respect their wishes to let the cops stay out. Adora isn’t here and what she doesn’t know won’t hurt her.” Catra couldn’t help a dry smile. Glimmer got better and better for every minute. “And 3. It’s COLD and I’m still WET! So if no one else has a problem with it, let’s go!”

Catra nodded, and Scorpia lifted up the unconscious robber over her shoulders. Perfuma just smiled. Scorpia and Glimmer was making their Merry way down the path. Catra was on her first step to run up to them when she stopped and sniffed the air. “Hey! What’s that sweet smell!?”

“It’s just my weed. I lit a small joint before I went inside.” Perfuma smiled back at Catra, as if it was the most natural thing in the world. Catra grunted.

“Okay. I hope you don’t have anything more, that smell gives me a headache.”

“Oh, no! I threw away the last stub I had just now.”

Catra froze. “Not… inside the barn?”

“Yes! Well, I suppose it would have been better to save it for a litter box, but honestly, I got so excited!”

“...It wasn’t still burning, was it?” Catra looked at Perfuma. She hadn’t forgotten the leaking gas can. She looked back, and her

smile went from happy to more and more uncertain as she began to realise what was stared inside the barn. Then they both turned around to see flames starting to grow inside the barn.

They started to run without any of them having to count to three.

This may not be the natural explanation, but it is the truth!

Chapter Notes

> This was going to be a christmas themed story, published over the holidays. Then things happened... But here is the penultimate chapter. Almost finally.

They got back to the apartment, successfully avoiding both the fire brigade and the police, to everyone pleasure. Glimmer also insisted on taking a detour so they passed a clothes store.

“I am DONE with these clothes! Jeans it is for the rest of this week even if it will kill the C.E.O on Parkinsons and Brothers,” She said when asked. The others just nodded.

Now they sat down in front of five steaming cups of tea, the robber placed in the comfiest chair, still wearing the trenchcoat and ski mask. Catra wanted to take it off immediately, but Glimmer said no. “She deserves to be awake. They are always conscious in Scooby Doo.”

“This isn’t a cartoon, Glimmer…”

“Sadly, no. It would have been much more fun if it were.” For once, Catra and Scorpia shared a worried glance.

“Um… guv, it’s not supposed to be fun…”

“Why not? There is nothing wrong with bringing a little happiness into your life!” Perfuma smiled a warm smile, to which Catra grimaced.

“Fuma, you're not really reading this situation, we…”

“Why did you guys think it was me?”

“What?/Huh?/Wuh?” Three confused faces turned at once at Perfuma. Catra could see Scorpia trying to read her wife’s face. Was she angry? Holding back? Oblivious? To Catra, she just looked wondering.

“Well, I’m not stupid.” Catra had to bite her lip, it was too good to pass. But she was behaving. Adulting. Again. As she said she would from the start. “First you called me," Perfuma continued, "You were obviously worried about me, and even if I MIGHT have been just a tad bit careless about the truth, I couldn’t find a reason for my wife, our friend and a complete stranger to start looking for me all over town. Then I find this strange figure keeping you at gunpoint. It was obvious that you thought it was me, and that this person had done something so evil that you had to find me. So I ask again. Why did you think it was me?”

“Um…”

“Well…”

“Now luv… that’s actually a rather funny story…”

“Is it really? From what I have seen it doesn’t seem like that.” The slight edge in Perfumas voice was not wasted on anyone. Scorpias shoulders slumped. Catra decided it was time to woman up.

“It was me. I saw you.... *Thought* I saw you in the street downtown.”

“Ookay…” There was a slight uncertainty in Perfumas voice suddenly.

“Yeah… You were standing on the street outside that store and…”

“YES?” *yeeesh, this woman is an emotional rollercoaster…* Loud she said,

“Then you put on a ski mask and went inside.”

“Heee… I can explain!”

“Then we heard two gunshots and then you… well, her, came running out and drove away on a motorcycle.”

“Heeeh… Well, you see, I… Wait, gunshots? I didn’t fire a gun! … not then anyway.”

“Well, it was gunshots! We both heard them!” Perfuma had gone from smiling, to judging, to scared and back to judging again now.

“I can’t believe you! Well, you, Glimmer I can, because I don’t know you and even if your vibe is good, you're still a god awful capitalist. But you, darling, you know me! I would NEVER use a gun like that! Haven’t you known me long enough to trust me? And Catra, you really need to work on your trust in people! I admit I have been doing some… questionable things from time to time… but they were all for a good cause! Robbing a store? Me? Taking money from the hard working man and putting it in my own pockets? Really?” They both looked away, Scorpia in shame, Catra wasn’t sure what she was looking away with.

“Well, I hope you have gotten something to think about! now…”

“Wait a minute!” Glimmer spoke up. “Okay, so you didn’t do the robbery, and therefore you didn’t steal Scorpias car and kidnapped us. That’s fine and dandy. BUT you looked awfully nervous earlier! Catras words hit a bit close to home and DON’T DENY IT! I have seen more than my share of embezzling economy directors to know when someone is trying to cover up. What have YOU been doing today? And how come you showed up with a gun at the exact right moment? HMMMM?”

“Yeah! That was awfully convenient! And I know that you would never use the spychips the government plants into us for selfish purposes! So what were you doing there?”

Catra gave Scorpia a glance. “Yeah… that…what she said.” Perfuma started to wave her hands in front of her.

“Now now… let’s not get upset here. Let’s focus on the positive energy in the room…”

"Fuma, you just told us we were jerks. the positive energy in this room is below zero."

Perfuma sighed. "Okay, okay… I guess it was silly of me to try to keep you out of it…"

***

"Alright! Everyone's ready? Ms Blue?"

"Ready."

"Miss White?"

"Yeah."

"Mx Brown?"

"Ready as ever!"

"Mrs Orange?"

"Why do I have to be orange? You all got cool aliases!"

"You're giving out such an orange vibe. And also, that was the only color that was left. You can't be two brown."

"Oh. Okay then! Ready!"

"Good. All balaclavas down. From now on, code names only. So, last run through of the plan. Blue?"

"Shutting down the electricity."

"White?"

"taking care of the doors."

"Brown?"

"I have the spray cans!"

"orange?"

"The 'Save the trees' posters are ready!"

"Awesome! Let's go!"

***

Seven minutes later.

"Run! Come one! Run! They're getting closer!"

"If I had known we had to run, I would have taken my running shoes and not my boots!"

"Yeah, why are we running? Wasn't blue supposed to take care of the electricity?"

"I did!"

"AND the alarm?"

"You never said anything about an alarm!"

"I thought that was understood!"

"Also, no one said anything about dogs!"

"Miranda, aren't you a dog person?"

"It's Mx Brown! and yes, but not wild beasts like this!"

"Aren't you the one who says pitbulls are misunderstood!?"

“MOST OF THEM, YES; BUT I’M NOT SURE THESE GUYS GOT THE MEMO!”

“QUICK! GET ON THE BUS!”

***

"Phew… Did we lose them?"

"I think so… Why is everyone staring at us?"

"I don't know. Hey you!"

"Take it! Take it all, just don't hurt me!"

"What!? No! I don't want your wallet!"

"Okay! Okay! Take my phone! And my watch!"

"Excuse me Sir? Is this the bus to Salinaeas?"

"I'll drive wherever you want, just don't hurt me!"

"No! Please, Sir! I just really REALLY need to…"

"THEY’RE DESPERATE! EVERYONE OFF THE BUS!"

***

"It was a bit rude for the driver to leave as well."

"Yeah. At least he could taken us to the bus station."

"People these days. Can we take of the balaclavas now?"

"No! If they learn our identities it's the end of the daughter's of plumeria. Can anyone drive a bus?"

"I can. I think."

*****

"You can't! You can't drive a bus!"

"Stop shouting and sit down! I can't see the road when you're in the way!"

"Watch out for the tree! Watch! Watch…"

"Ssh! Can you keep it low? My wife is calling!?"

"Easier said than done when this idiot is driving!"

"Hey! That was rude!"

"Hi sweetie! What's up?"

"Don'trunoverthemanonthebike!!!"

"Yes, I see that it's you. What's the matter? I am in a bit of a hurry now so please be quick."

"Turn left! No not until the actual corneeer!

"Oh. Well… you see... I had to take care of something. "

"You're lucky you didn't hit that dog!"

"Oh, nothing special. Just something I needed to fix. Business."

"Shit! The police!"

" Well…"

"'HANDS WHERE I CAN SEE THEM!'

"I...need to hang up. Talktoyoulateraeeyouatdinnerbye."

"HIT THE GAS!"

*****

"Okay. You couldn't drive a bus."

"I managed to shake the cops off, didn't I?"

"Only because you drove through the car… also, hitting the only oak tree in half a mile?"

"It came at me without warning!"

"Ladies! Please! Stop arguing! You're ruining the mood. Anyway, we're almost at the base anyway. Same time next week?"

"Yeah."

"Sure."

"Okay!"

"The fight must continue! Hey, Helen, can I hitch a ride with you?"

"Sure. Perfuma, do you want a lift?"

"No thanks. I'm good. A walk will do me good. I will just check the supplies, I'm not sure if we have enough gasoline to set that

factory on fire. Also, I need to put my gun away."

"Okay. Well, have a nice day!"

"You to! Tell Marilyn and the kids I said hi!"

***

As Perfuma finished her tale, Glimmer had slowly moved herself further and further away from her. Catra was the one to break the silence.

“Were you using that old barn as you base?”

“Shed. And yes. It’s small, but it filled it’s purpose.”

“So… The gasonline?” Perfuma looked away.

“It’s better if you don’t know.”

"Ookay. But really, Perfuma! You tried to break into a shop."

"A wood goods store. They keep buying wood from exploiters!"

"Okay. Still a break in. And you wore the ski masks all the time?"

"Yes."

"And you carried a gun the whole time?"

"...mhm…" Glimmer pinched her nose, scorpia gave Perfuma a nervous but encouraging smile and Catra raised her eyebrows.

"And you ask ME why I assumed you had robbed a liquor store?"

Perfuma looked around the room, at everything save for the other three.

"Okay… So maybe I have done some questionable deeds today…"

"YOU THINK?"

"But! In that case, any time you see a robbery, you must assume it's me then! Or was it something else that gave you the impression?"

Catra didn't have to answer because now there was the sound of movement from the chair where they had put the robber. In an instant they were all over her.

"What the f…"

"Be silent, fiend!" The stance was nice, but Perfumas comment only made the robber confused. Catra rolled her eyes.

"What?"

"Just sit still, okay? Let's see who you are…Scorp?"

“on it!”

Scorpia pinched the ski mask with her craw like hand and slowly pulled it off. They all stared at the face that looked up at them with venom in her eyes.

It was a copy of perfuma. Sure, a bit more weathered, and the hair was as brown and ratty as Perfuma was blond, but the facial features were screamingly alike down to the freckles. They were all silent until the robber spoke up.

"Take a fucking picture."

"Damn…"

"It's...jarring…"

"It's actually a bit scary…"

The robber frowned. "Oh come on! It's not that bad!" They all shared a glance with each other.

"N-no, it’s not how you look but…"

"It's really… I mean… We thought…"

"You thought what? ...Wait a minute! You're not the cops! You're the same dweebs that sat in the car I jacked!"

"Well...yes."

"You were talking some rubbish about how you saw me outside that liquor store and then you said you followed me!?"

"Welll...um… Yeah. We did."

"We thought you were…"

"I didn't think!" Glimmer butted in.

"Neither did I. It was all you, wildcat." Catra frowned.

"Well, thanks for throwing me under the bus here!"

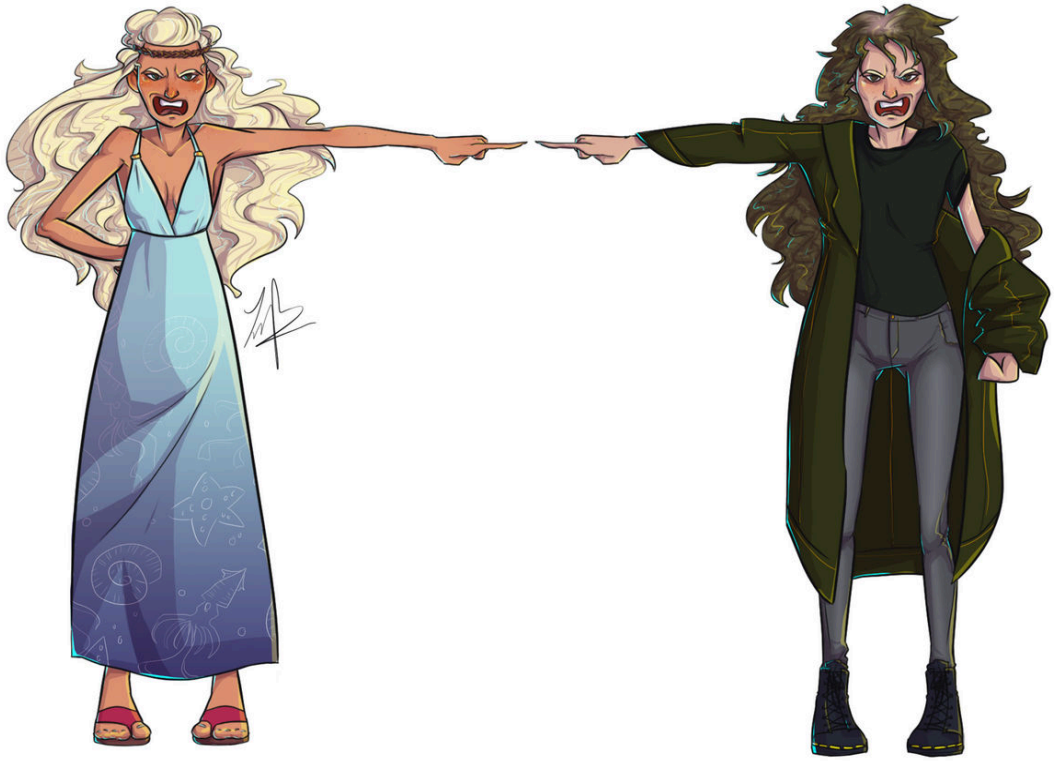
"SHUT UP! YOU'RE ALL INSANE! NOW ANSWER ME! Why did you guys chase me? And why the hell would you think I was her?”

“You… are… quite alike.”

"WHAT?" Perfuma exclaimed, in chorus with the robber,

"No way!"

Glimmer and Scorpia nodded. The robber stood up from the chair, then she took a few steps towards Perfuma. She looked at her from head to toes, Perfuma did the same. Then they both looked at the other three, then again at each other with disgust and then back to the three. Flashes shot from their eyes as they pointed at each other and simultaneously and with equally shrill voices shouted: “WE ARE NOTHING ALIKE!”



“I mean, I don’t look the slightest like her!”

“Would I wear THAT?”

“Our voices are completely disparate” Glimmer raised a finger.

“You… actually have rather similar voices.”

“No we’re not!” They both answered at the same time.

“We have nothing in common!”

“What’s your name by the way? I’m Perfuma. She/they.”

“Whu? She/they? Oh. That thing. She/her. And the name’s Aroma… Why are you snickering?”

Catra did her best to bite her lip. “Nothing… nothing at all. Aroma and Perfuma…”

The robber, Aroma, glared at her. “Thought so. And I mean… Who wears those dresses?”

“And her hair? Eugh! I bet she uses shampoo!”

Aroma paused and looked at Perfuma. “And what exactly is wrong with using shampoo?”

“Well, first of all, it is feeding the corporations money they already have too much of and second, it damages your hair! I only use hot water, some herbal oils and a brush. And maybe conditioner from time to time, but that is all! You could probably use some oils as well.”

“Don’t try any of your hippie mumbo-jumbo on ME!”

"It's not mumbo-jumbo! It's scientifically proven!"

"Shut up! This is crazy! You're all insane! You let me go NOW!"

With that said, she pulled up her gun from under her trench coat. Catra, Glimmer and Scorpia slowly raised their hands.

"Didn’t you take the gun?"

"I did! I put it on the… table…"

"Scorpia…"

"Okay! Drop the gun!" Again Perfuma uttered those words, again she had a gun in her hand. But this time she stood behind the robber/Aroma, pressing the cold metal to her neck. "Oh Sweet Spirits! It's even worse from here! You could at least see a good hairdresser!"

"STAY OUT OF MY HAIR!"

“Can you both PLEASE lower your guns before you have an argument over your hair?” In this very moment, Glimmer thoroughly wished Bow to be here. Maybe he wouldn't have made a more intelligent comment, but she could really use a hug.

“Yeah! And besides, Perfuma is right. You would benefit from some conditioner.”

“Scorpia…” Catra pinched her nose.

“What? Is it a crime to agree with your trouble and.. .. I mean Wife?”

"Thank you dear. Now put the gun down or I will…" Aroma glared, but she put the gun down. Glimmer was quick to take it and aimed it at Aroma.

"Put the gun down, Glimmer!" Glimmer looked at Perfuma in confusion.

"But. But… what?"

" I am a strict believer in non-violence! I am not going to use this gun and neither are you!"

"You brought the gun with you! Not only here, but to that protest or whatever it was as well! " Perfuma took a deep breath and closed her eyes. Then she said slowly,

"We were just going to do a peaceful protest, that was all.”

“You still brought a gun.”

“Look! It was down in the Crimson area! Do you know the risk of getting mugged there?”

“....”

“Told you so. Besides, it’s not even loaded.” At those words, Scorpia began to wiggle herself.

“Um… Actually, bae... “

Perfuma suddenly got very pale. “It...is?”

“It’s… mums old Webley & Scott…”

“O...kay…”

“Perfuma? Babe? Don’t panic now, okay?”

"Ookkay…" Perfuma turned green in her face and slowly fell down on the floor. Catra, Glimmer and Aroma looked at her, then at Scorpia. Glimmer was the one who broke the silence.

“Didn’t you say she burnt down a house once? I thought she would have stronger nerves." Scorpia hmpfd.

“Burning down a house is completely different from using a gun!”

Aroma had sat down. At first she had just stared at the others, in the end she shrugged her shoulders and drank her tea.

"Hmm. Not bad."

"Thanks."

"Okay. Aroma. No guns. Just us."

"Try one of me chocolate orange biscuits mate!"

Aroma looked from Scorpia to Glimmer.

"Is this some weird Good cop-bad cop routine, Sparkly?"

Catra answered before Glimmer could open her mouth,"No, she's just bitchy by nature."

"Catra…"

Catra smirked. Aroma leaned back. "Whatever. Just get it over with. Call 911 and have it done."

"Nope. Not yet. "

Aroma sighed and took another sip.

“Why did you do it?”

Silence.

"Come on. Why did you do it? It's a small store, you wouldn't get much."

“Duh. She needed the money.”

“Yeah, sparkly. Listen to your girlfriend.

“SHE’S NOT MY GIRLFRIEND/SHE ISN’T MY GIRLFRIEND!”

“Huh. Could have fooled me.” Glimmer leaned down so she was in Aromas face.

“Don’t change the subject. Now, we may or may not call the police. Depending on your answer. And be honest.”

“Hah. How would you know if I am lying? I can tell you a weepy cock-and bull story as much as I want and you wouldn’t be wiser.”

“You more or less just outed yourself for one. And second…The truth will always set us free.”

“Not me.”

“Tell us and we’ll see.”

“Fuck off.” There was a certain kind of light in Aromas eyes. A defiant glance, a who-the-fuck-cares-look. Catra knew it well, she had seen it in herself many times. So maybe, just maybe… Catra sat down next to Aroma. She looked up, as Catra took her cup of tea, leaned back, and spoke.

“Look. I grew up in a rough neighbourhood. Now, I didn’t exactly cross the line but let’s just say I lived close to it for a few years. I think I know the difference between someone who wants a criminal life and someone who has nothing to lose. And also, you never rob a liqour store before lunch. They never have any good money then. WHat? I said it was close a few times!” She added,

when Glimmer and scorpia gave her a strange look. “How much did you get?”

“25 bucks. The register was almost empty.” Catra nodded. “Figures.”

“But why did you steal the car?”

“I… My bike ran out of gas. I was considering robbing the gas station but.. I didn’t really have the nerves left. And when I saw tank girl here leave the hatch open… Well… I had no idea you’d be in it!”

“Why didn’t you stop and…”

“I PANICKED; OKAY?”

“Are you SURE you aren’t related to Perfuma?”

“Scorp. Shush. Go on.” Aroma was silent for a few minutes. Then it slowly began to trickle out of her.

“I… Have a daughter. 5 years. Named Pomona. She’s… such a good girl. Has the best smile…” She was silent again. “But… Well… I haven’t… been the best mom. I used to be in the army but I… Things got rough and I was precluded. And things just got messy after that. I couldn’t deal with life, her, my relationship… So I’m out on the street and she lives with her dad. He’s…I know he’s doing what he thinks is best but… I just want visitation rights! I am keeping myself in line! I have been clean from drugs for over two years.”

“You still robbed a store…”

“I need money for a lawyer. They’re thieves anyway. Do you mind if I have a smoke?”

“Oh yeah/Not all/ some are, yeah.” Scorpia, Glimmer and Catra looked at each other.

“WHAT? It’s true!?”

“Sure Scorp.” Glimmer had been silent for a while, save for the last comment. Now she said with afterthought,

“Well… I get the desperation, and sure. If we are to act out of pity we would just let you go, but… You did fire two shots at the store!”

“They were blanks.”

“Really?”

“Really.”

“But… the one in the barn?

“ Blank.”

“Why did the barrel start to leak?”

“Maybe it was just old.” They were silent for a while, again. Glimmer took another biscuit, and so did Aroma. Again it was Catra that spoke.

“Okay. So, I still don’t want to be involved with the cops. Once a fright zone kid, always a fright zone kid. Scorpia… we know her opinion. Aroma wants to get to see her kid, and a record would effectively cut her off. Only one who wants to turn her in is you, Glimglam.” Glimmer placed her

“She tried to rob a liquor store, she stole a car, kidnapped us and tried to shoot us!”

“Not for real!”

Glimmerstood with her arms akimbo, glaring at Catra and Aroma,“It sure felt real! Besides, there’s also Perfuma! The police will find the barn, and I bet they will find fingerprints from all of us! And…. Okay, just need to take this.” She got interuppted by

her phone. “Yeah, Glimmer. Oh, Hello Mr Flywheel. What? A FI… fire? Where? IN BRIGHTMOON? I didn’t even know I owned a shed... Oh. Part of the old… " She paused and gave Catra a long look. "What? Yes, I'm still here. Okay. Completely overheated when the firemen arrived? Nothing left. Okay… If I want an investigation?” She was silent. Catra gave her a pleading look. Glimmer didn’t look back. Finally she said “No… Leave it. It doesn’t sound like it was any value any way. As long as no one was hurt. Yeah. Ok. Yeah, thanks. Take care!” She put the phone away.

"That was one of my solicitors. He was kind enough to inform me that a property I owned in Brightmoon was found burned to the ground to day. A shed, part of the old McKenzie farm, apparently once used as a roost/tool shed.”

Everyone looked at their feet, except Aroma, who seemed to be enjoying the show, at least she smirked (which looked extremely weird with a face akin to Perfumas).

“Yes! The only thing left standing after you tore down the entire farm and replaced it with a…” Glimmer silenced her with one look. This was her show.

“Exactly WHEN were you going to tell me that the shed was on fire?"

"Well…"

“Um… Scorp?”

“You see…”

“I can’t believe you! You think that keeping silent will keep you out of trouble? Do you think the firebrigade WON’T call the police?” She looked from Catra to Scorpia. Aroma took another one of Scorpias cookies and waited for the next part.

“...Maybe they can find forgiveness in their hearts?”

Glimmer splayed her hands and screamed, "Shut up! You realise that almost everything that would have proven this weird day has even happened just got lost in… the fire…" Glimmer became silent and sat for a few minutes in thought.

“Okay… I guess that took care of everything. No proof of Perfumas gang being there, no prints from us, and the footprints probable moshed away by the law enforcement…"

Scorpia smiled. “Yep! A perfect happy ending! Perfuma is still free, you guys are free and Aroma is…”

“... still having trouble with her life. I need that lawyer anyway, even if you don’t turn me in.” Aroma spoke, not with Acid in her voice but with a voice of someone who had given up. Howver, Catra began to smile. She looked at Glimmer, who slowly realised what kind of Idea she had got.

“A lawyer. Perhaps I have a solution to that…”

Epilogue (for real this time. I promise!)

Chapter Notes

And done.

Present day

Adora blinked. once. Twice. Thrice. Fours. Fivers. Finn had just got back with the beverage (and a face full of blueberry cinnamon bun) and she grabbed the first mug she found and emptied it in one go. Then she immediately spit it out.

“Ble! Ungh! Aaaah! Hot! Sugary! Hot!”

“Yeah, I think that was mom’s chocolate, mom.”

“Think again, kid.” Catra shook her head. "It was Glimmer’s. Ours are safe.” With a smile, she took one of the remaining mugs, checked it carefully, and took a sip. “Yep, this one’s right. Here you go, Finn. Now let’s see… Coffee. Here, Adora. Clean the pipes.”

Glimmer frowned. “And why, pray tell me, was it MY cocoa that got spittakened?”

“Because you are a generous and kind person who doesn’t mind buying her own cocoa when her poor friends screw up.” Catra gave Glimmer her biggest kitten-eyes, the reaction was a headshake, and a start to get up from the chair, but Adora stopped her.

“Sit down, Glim. I’ll get you a new one. I just got.. a little… I mean… That was some story…” She swallowed. “So… That Aroma girl that arrived at our office…”

“Yup. We figured she could use some help from the She-Ra.”

Adora gave Glimmer a long look. Then she sighed and laughed a dry laugh. “What a mess…”

“Eh. Nothing really, compared to the Best Friend Squads latest adventure.” Glimmer smirked again.

“You know, Catra… A series of weird and seemingly random events… I say you are a prospect to the Best Friend Squad.”

Now it was Catras' turn to do a spit-take. “NO! HEeeeCK no!” (Finns shook their head)

“Oh, but Catra! You’re practically already in it! We just have to find another…” Glimmer put her hand on Catra’s shoulder but she pulled away.

“No no no! I’m not… You’re not going to get me dragged into another mess just to get me into your stupid group!”

“Okay, so you are in if I'm not getting you dragged into another mess then?”

“I didn’t say that!”

Catra made a face, Glimmer smirked and Adora smiled.

“I would love to have you in the BFS. Actually, I thought you were a part of it already.”

“Nope. I was just an observer.” She paused. “Alright, alright… I think about it, okay,” she added when she saw the pout on Adoras lips.

“THAT’S a decision I drink to!” Glimmer took the cup Adora had molested, checked to see if there was any cocoa left,lifted it to the sky and saluted. Catra did the same with her filled cup. Adora smiled, and did the same with her coffee.

“I wish Bow was here.” Adora added with a slight sad sigh. Glimmer shrugged her shoulders.

“Eh. He will just be happy knowing there’s new members coming in. We should consider adding more prospects. Scorpia is a sweetie. And Perfuma is actually rather intelligent if you take the time to listen to her.”

“Sparkles… Isn’t it being a bit too nepotistic to hire her as ‘eco-consultant’? ”

“Keep your friends close, your enemies closer. This way I can make sure my company stays on the right side of climate change while keeping her far away from gas cans and molotov cocktails. Also, pot calling the kettle black?”

“I don’t know what you are talking about.”

“Sure you do. Those biscuits…”

“I never ate them.”

“Your loss. I told you, those biscuits were to die for! And especially now, when she has the ability to bake for a living, less eco-terror and more biscuits.”

“When can I meet this Scorpia? She sounds like a… fascinating person.” Glimmer smiled. Catra Groaned.

“Yes, CATRA. Where CAN Adora meet her? Hmmm?” Catra looked away, making a face. Slowly she began to speak.

“If… you… come with me to… work, I can… introduce you. It’s nothing, stop looking at me like that! They had an open spot in the kitchen. I just happened to mention a name. I would have done it earlier, had she told me how tough things were…” She looked up to see Adora smile a wide beaming grin and Glimmer sending a smug smile her way.

“What?” Adora stood up from her chair, walked over to Catra and gave her a big hug and a kiss.

“You are such a big hearted warm cuddly person under all that attitude.” She paused and looked into Catras' eyes. “I love that more than anything in you.”

“Get a room, moms! And not one next to mine!” This managed to get both women blushing.

“Have you heard…”

“NO. But only because you haven’t got your thumbs out. It’s a precaution. I have the room right over nans’ when I stay the night there.”

Catra began to straight out laugh as Adora buried her face in her hands, groaning.

“Your mom is a damn Cougar, Adora! Well, I am glad to know what I can look forward to.” Catra laughed. With Another groan, Adora stood up and grabbed Finn's hand.

“Come here, Kid. We are going to buy Glimmer a new cocoa and then we are going back to the skating track. I need to exercise the image from my mind.”

“Hey! Why am I coming with you?”

“Punishment for being a brat.” She smiled at Finn. “And if you keep the attitude, I may have to silence you with another bun.”

“YAY!”

And they left. Glimmer cleared her throat. “Cat? I don’t want to oppose, but IF you want to re-marry her, Dad happens to own a resort… a venue that can take around 500 guests… nothing big.”

“500? Glim, I don’t have that many friends.”

“Too bad. Already booked it.”

“Sparkles…”

“Alright, alright… I booked it for a conference in may. But I may be able to move it…” She twinkled her eyes, Catra groaned.

“Okay, I can’t lie, that would be awesome but… There is no way I can return the favour!”

“Catra. You don’t have to. I am just doing a friend a favour.” She put her hand on Catras. Catra looked up. Glimmer smiled, so did Catra after a second.

“Thanks, Glimmer… Let me think about it? And I still want to do SOMETHING for you but… I mean… I only have complete access to the cleaners storage.” She paused again. “I guess I can give you a year's supply of rubber gloves, that should last through a whole year of sewer-clogging. With that hair, I can only imagine how often that happens…”

“YOU’RE the one to talk about HAIR!"

“I have a DOUBLE supply!” Catra smirked and Glimmer groaned. “Okay, I have givin it a thought. 1 I love the gesture, but I want, WE want something smaller. Just you guys, Scorp, Fuma… That’s enough for me right now. However, 2 I… no, 2, you CAN buy the cake if you want.” She gave Glimmer a long look, seemingly thinking about how to proceed and finally spoke, “And 3, that’s a much more proper way of telling Adora how much you love her.”

Glimmer stared. “Now THAT’S a face I haven’t seen in two weeks.” Catra smugged.

“I…what?”

“Come on, Glim. You didn’t think I knew? The real reason you hated me? You have the biggest crush on Adora. Always have.”

Glimmer stood up from her chair, then she realized that Adora might be watching so she looked in the direction where she had gone. She saw Adora and Finn chasing each other around the track. She sat down again and said in a controlled voice. “Catra. I like Adora. As a friend. And I am very very happy and in love with

Bow and I am not saying that as some sort of mantra trying to convince myself. I AM in love with him."

Catra nodded. "I know you are. People in love look like sheep."

"Hey!"

"Suck it up, it's true. And don't try to bullshit me on this. I know. I have been in love with Adora for over 20 years. I know what it means to love her. And I know how you look at her when you love her." Catra looked deep into Glimmer's eyes. At first she looked away, but finally their eyes met again.

"Okay… You're right. I love her."

"Of course I'm right. Even when you get hitched, even if you have thousands of kids, even if you settle down in the Bahamas with him in your 70's, you will always love her." She pulled her chair closer. "I know what it means to love her. She is one in a million.And you know how messed up College and High school was. I was sure I never had a chance back then. I mean, when we finally got our shit together, I was sure I was breaking something between you. It took me a while to realize that… Yeah."

Glimmer looked down on the table. "Yeah… I tried… She never said it straight out, she didn't want to hurt me…"

"Yeah. Classic Adora."

"But she doesn't like me like that… And there you came, being everything I'm not…" Glimmer looked at the track again, watching Adora pushing Finn into a pile of snow, laughing as she pulled them out only to get a snowball in the face. Still laughing, she throw one back at Finn and the hunt began anew. Glimmer was silent the whole time.

"The worst part is that it felt like you didn't even try. One day it was 'this is Catra, an old pal' the next week you were all over each other. And sure, I knew what Adora said, about you dancing

around each other's feelings and all that but… It was hard to believe. Then."

"I guess you were happy when we broke up then?"

"Actually, no. Or…50/50. I said that I thought you were bad for Adora but… That was something I more or less told myself. Or… the last year you were together was… It was so easy being mad."

Catra looked away. She knew how that year had been…

"Look, Sparkles. I AM sorry I messed up your happy ending but…" Now Glimmer put her hand on Catras shoulder.

"I had given up hope already. I realized that I had more fun with her as a friend than anything else but… I didn't want to stop being angry with you. The hurt was gone but I was still angry. If you can understand that."

Catra shook her head and put her hand on Glimmer's. "Hello Pot. Adora says that all the time, but don't tell her she's right. She says we're really alike you and I. And we are."

"Yeah. I know."

"You are right. I will - we will - always love her. It's… I low-key believe in destiny. This time it was you and her. In another universe, it would have been us. In yet another universe, you would have hooked up with Scorpia in that Camp, Adora would have fallen for her PT and I would have been a nun."

"A nun? look, Glimmer…"

"Don't interrupt! I am being deep." She took a deep breath. " In yet another it would have been you and I. Running a kingdom. In a desert. Being madly in love and fighting to the death as foreplay." Glimmer looked deep into Catras eyes.. Catra blushed all the way from her forehead to her neck.

“SPARKLES!” Glimmer held her eyes focused on Catra for a few minutes more, then she laughed. Catra groaned and pulled away her hand.

“Fuck you, sparkle-bitch."

“Already taken. Want another cocoa, Cat-turd?”

“You bet, Sparkles.”

THE END

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